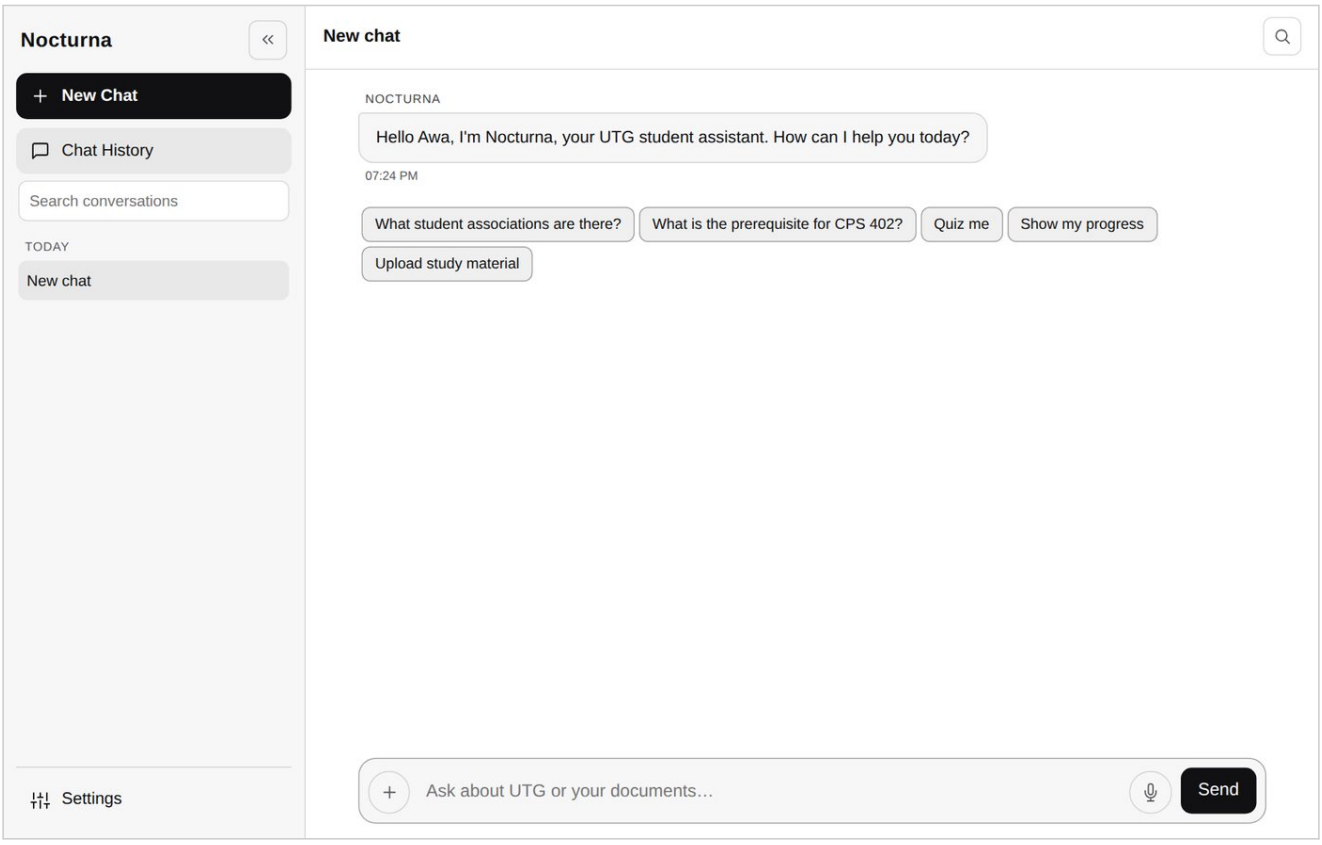
Nocturna
User Guide

The University of The Gambia student assistant
A step-by-step guide with screenshots of every screen



Version 2.0 | October 2026

Contents

1. What Nocturna is . . . 3
2. Installing and starting Nocturna . . . 3
3. Creating an account and signing in . . . 3
4. A tour of the screen . . . 6
5. Asking a question . . . 6
6. The + menu . . . 9
7. Uploading a document . . . 10
8. Asking about a document . . . 11
9. Notes . . . 14
10. Quizzes . . . 15
11. Flashcards . . . 17
12. Study plan . . . 18
13. Progress . . . 20
14. Past exam analyzer . . . 21
15. Coding help and search . . . 22
16. Settings . . . 24
17. Using Nocturna on a phone . . . 31
18. Your privacy . . . 32
19. Troubleshooting . . . 33
20. Quick reference . . . 33

1. What Nocturna is

Nocturna is a web chatbot for students of the University of The Gambia (UTG). You sign in, type a question, and Nocturna answers from three sources only:

- the **UTG knowledge base**: facts about the university taken from UTG's own information;
- the **UTG course catalogue**: programmes, schools and entry requirements;
- **your own documents**, such as lecture notes, which you upload yourself.

Nocturna does **not** use any AI or large language model. It never invents an answer. When it quotes your documents it shows the original text together with the page and section it came from, and when it does not know something it says so. Besides answering questions it helps you study: it can make notes, quizzes, flashcards and study plans from your material and show how you are progressing.

All screenshots in this guide were taken from the real application. They show the light theme; section 16.1 explains how to switch to the dark theme.

2. Installing and starting Nocturna

2.1 What you need

- A computer with **Python 3.10 or newer**.
- A modern web browser (Chrome, Edge, Firefox or Safari).
- The Nocturna project folder, `nocturna_utg`.
- No internet connection is needed to use Nocturna. It is only used by the optional weather command and to load the page font.

2.2 Steps

1. Open a terminal inside the `nocturna_utg` folder.
2. Create a virtual environment and activate it (commands below).
3. Install the required packages.
4. Start the application.
5. Open your browser at `http://127.0.0.1:5000`.

```
python -m venv .venv
.venv\Scripts\activate          (Windows)
source .venv/bin/activate         (macOS / Linux)
pip install -r requirements.txt
python app.py
```

> **Note** Leave the terminal window open while you use Nocturna. Press Ctrl+C in the terminal to stop it. To enable the weather command, set the environment variable OPENWEATHER_API_KEY to your own key before starting.

3. Creating an account and signing in

3.1 Your UTG student email

Only students with a **UTG student email** can sign up or log in. Your email is made from your name and your student number:

first letter of your first name + first letter of your second name + your student number + @utg.edu.gm

Name	Student number	UTG email
Awa Jallow	2211234	aj2211234@utg.edu.gm

Name	Student number	UTG email
Lamin Ceesay	2305678	lc2305678@utg.edu.gm
Awa Fatou Jallow (three names)	2211234	aj2211234@utg.edu.gm or af2211234@utg.edu.gm

- The two letters must match the name you type when you sign up.
- The student number has 4 to 10 digits. Capital letters do not matter.
- A personal address such as Gmail, or any address that does not end in `@utg.edu.gm`, is refused.
- Accounts that were created earlier with a different address can no longer log in. Create a new account with your UTG email.

> **Note** Nocturna checks the **format** of your email and that the letters match your name. It does not check your student number against the registrar's records.

3.2 Sign up (first time only)

1. Open Nocturna in your browser. On the login page choose **Create an account** (Figure 1).
2. Enter your **full name**: your first name and your second name (Figure 3).
3. Enter your **UTG student email**, for example `aj2211234@utg.edu.gm`.
4. Enter a **password** of at least 8 characters, then type it again to confirm.
5. Press **Create account**. You are taken straight to the chat (Figure 5).

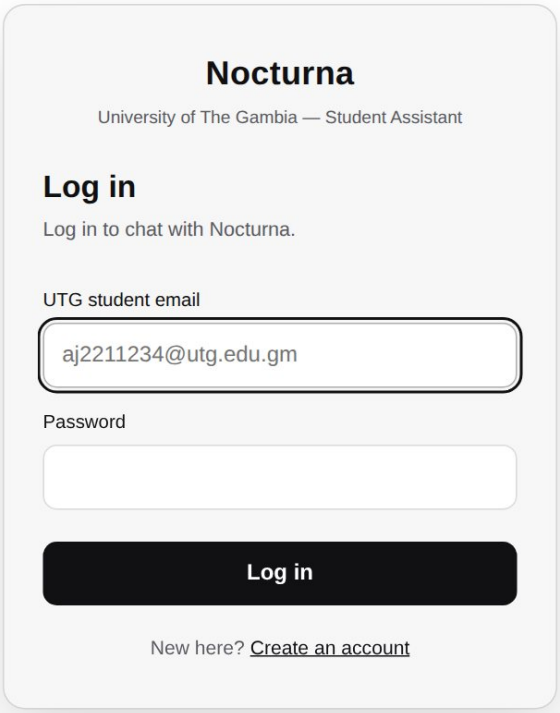


Figure 1: The login page.

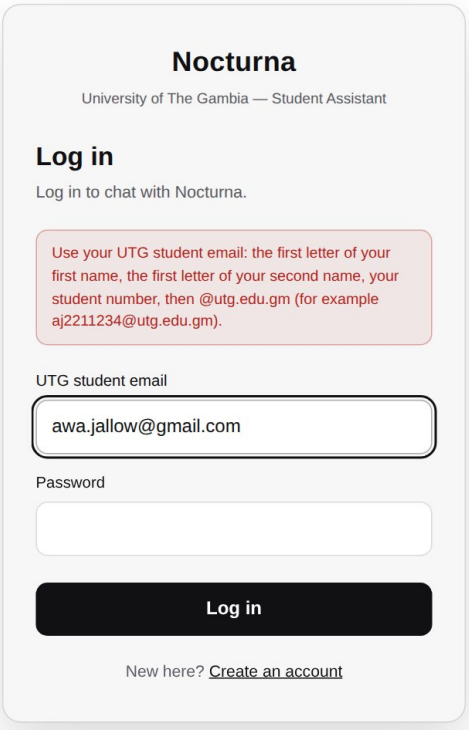


Figure 2: Login with a non-UTG email is refused.

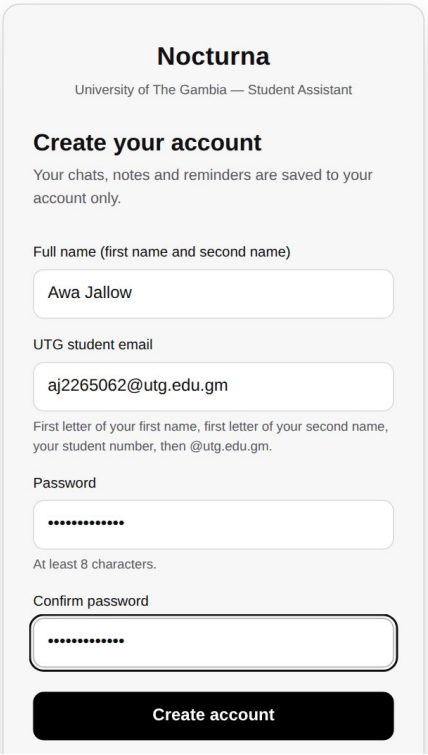


Figure 3: The sign-up page, filled in with a UTG email.

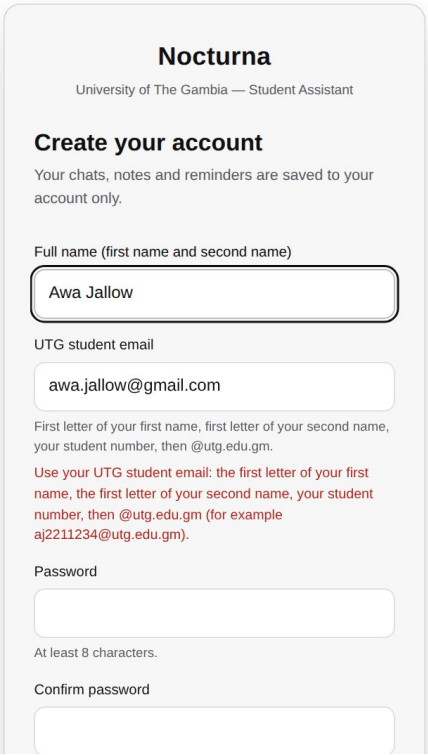


Figure 4: A non-UTG email gets a message under the email box.

If the email or name is not accepted, a red message appears under the box (Figure 4) and nothing is saved. The most common reasons are a personal email address, letters that do not match your name, a student number that is too short, or typing only one name.

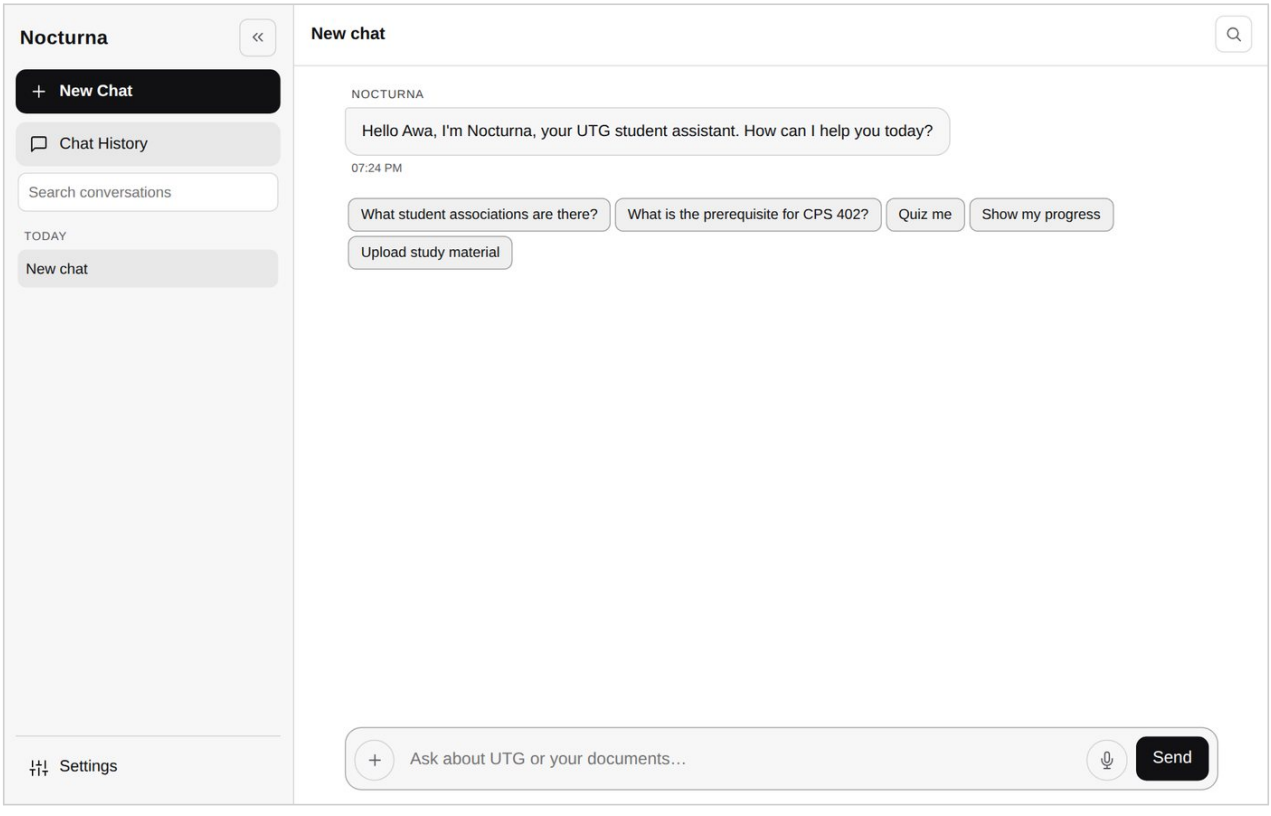


Figure 5: The chat screen after signing up. Nocturna greets you by name.

3.3 Logging in and out

- On later visits enter your **UTG student email** and your password on the login page and press **Log in**.
- If the email is not a UTG student email, the page explains the format (Figure 2). If the details are wrong, the message says only 'incorrect email or password'. After 5 failed attempts for the same email within 10 minutes, login is paused for a short while to protect your account.
- To log out, open **Settings**, then the **User Profile / Account** tab, and press **Log out** (section 16.3).
- The small sun/moon button on the login and sign-up pages switches between light and dark.

4. A tour of the screen

The chat screen has three parts (Figure 5):

Part	What it contains
Sidebar (left)	Exactly three items. **New Chat** starts a fresh conversation. **Chat History** lists your past conversations and has a search box. **Settings** opens the settings window. The double-arrow button at the top collapses the sidebar.
Conversation (centre)	Your messages and Nocturna's replies. The magnifying-glass button at the top right opens search.
Message box (bottom)	The **+** button (attach files and study tools), the text field, a microphone button (if your browser supports speech) and **Send**.

All icons are plain single-colour line icons, so the interface looks the same in the light and dark themes.

5. Asking a question

1. Click the message box and type your question, for example *What are the tuition fees at UTG?* (Figure 6).
2. Press **Enter** or the **Send** button. Use **Shift+Enter** to start a new line inside a message.
3. Your message appears and the word **Thinking** shows below it with moving dots (Figure 7). Nocturna replies after about **5 seconds**. This pause is intentional, and the Send button is switched off while Nocturna thinks so you cannot send a second message by accident.
4. The reply appears with its **source** and a **time** (Figure 8). Click a document source to open that document.

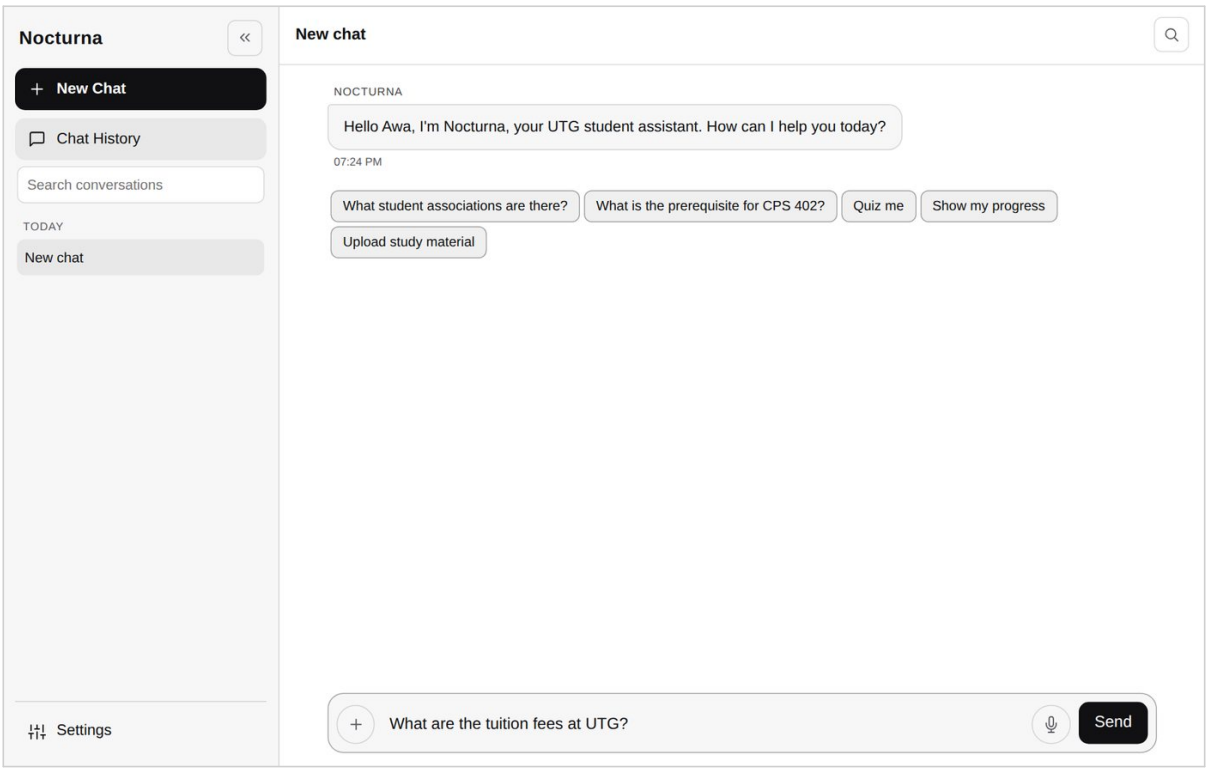


Figure 6: Typing a question.

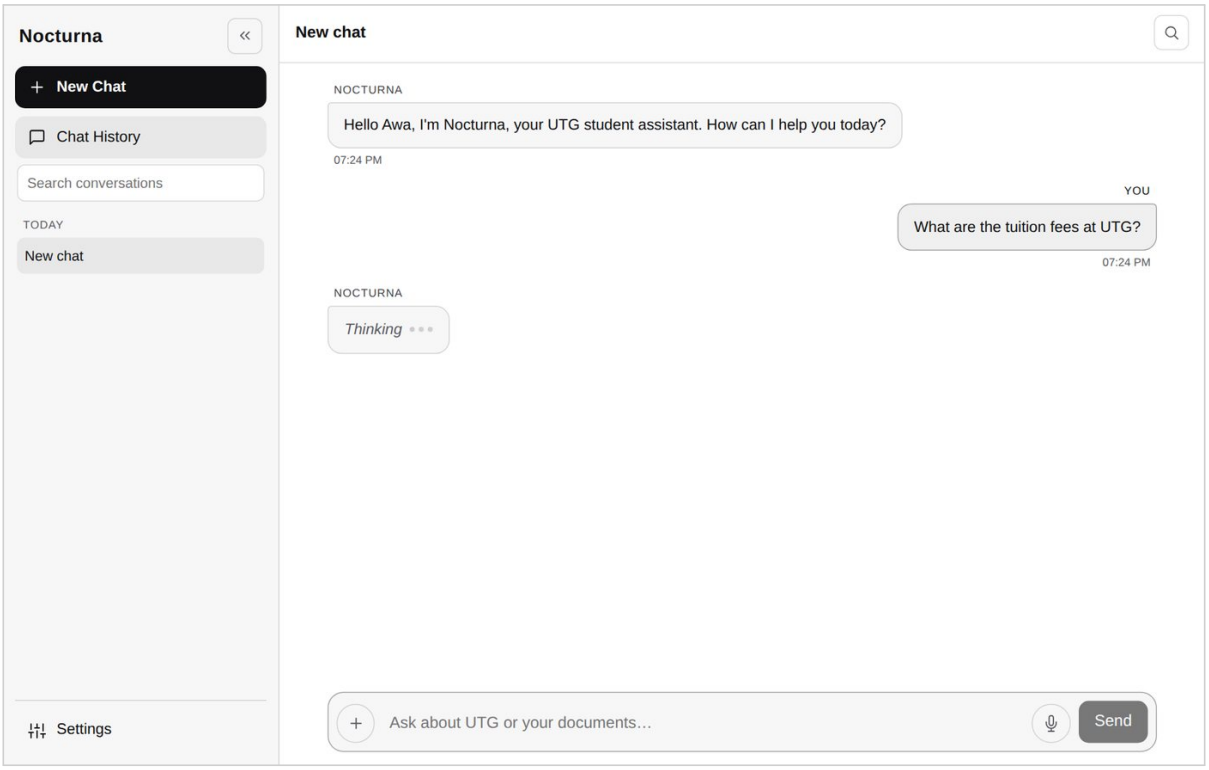


Figure 7: Nocturna shows 'Thinking' under your message.

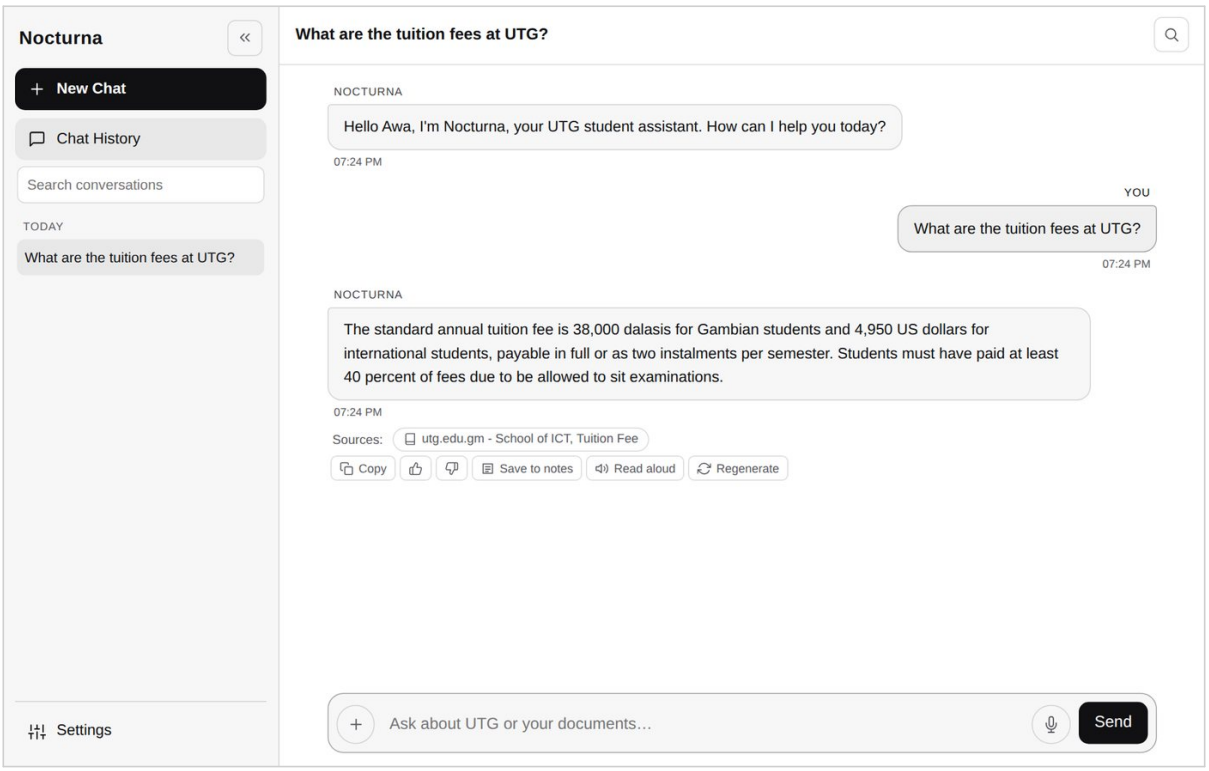


Figure 8: The answer, with its source, the time and the action buttons.

5.1 Buttons under a reply

Button	What it does
Copy	Copies the reply to the clipboard.
Thumbs up / thumbs down	Tells us whether the answer helped.
Save to notes	Stores the reply as a note you can find later.
Read aloud	Reads the reply out loud (if your browser supports it).
Regenerate	Asks the same question again.

5.2 What you can ask

- **About UTG:** schools and faculties, programmes, admission requirements, tuition fees, how to apply, where UTG is and who to contact.
- **Everyday help:** the time, jokes, weather (needs a key), a web-search link, a map link, notes and reminders. Type **help** to see the full list.
- **Your study material:** after uploading a document, ask about it (sections 7 and 8).
- **Study tools:** phrases such as *quiz me*, *make flashcards*, *study plan*, *show my progress* or *my notes*.

> **Tip** If Nocturna says 'I'm still learning', rephrase using the same words UTG uses, for example 'school of medicine programmes'. Nocturna answers only from its UTG data and your documents, so it will not guess.

5.3 Your conversations

Every conversation is saved and listed in the sidebar under **Chat History** (Figure 9), grouped as Today, Yesterday, Previous 7 days and Older. Click one to reopen it. Type in the search box to find a conversation. Hover over a conversation to show a pencil icon (rename) and a bin icon (delete). Press **New Chat** to start a new conversation.

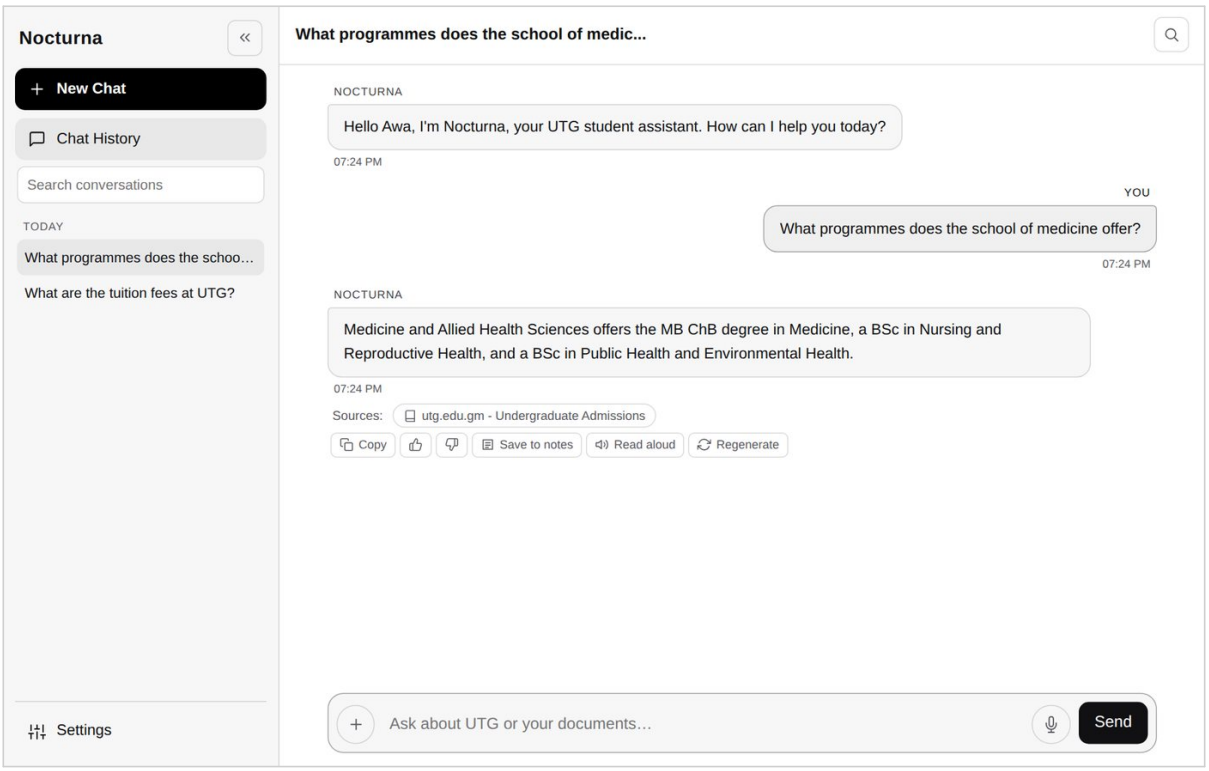


Figure 9: Chat History in the sidebar with two saved conversations.

6. The + menu

The **+** button next to the message box opens the menu of study tools (Figure 10). Each item is explained in the sections that follow.

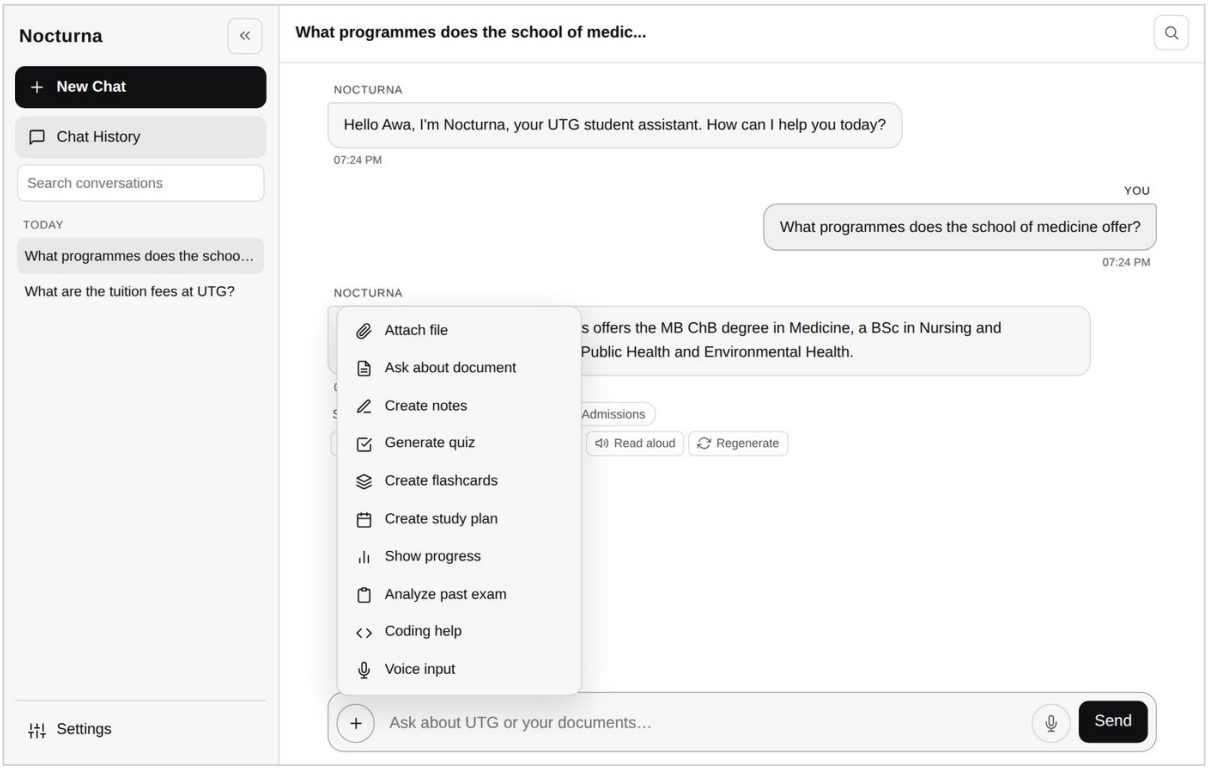


Figure 10: The + menu.

Menu item	Section
Attach file	7. Uploading a document

Menu item	Section
Ask about document	8. Asking about a document
Create notes	9. Notes
Generate quiz	10. Quizzes
Create flashcards	11. Flashcards
Create study plan	12. Study plan
Show progress	13. Progress
Analyze past exam	14. Past exam analyzer
Coding help	15. Coding help
Voice input	Speak your message (browser support required)

7. Uploading a document

1. Press **+** and choose **Attach file**. The *Attach study material* window opens (Figure 11).
2. Optionally choose a **course**, and choose the **type**: *Study material* (notes, slides, textbook) or *Past exam paper*.
3. Drag your file onto the dashed area, or press **Browse Files**. Nocturna accepts **PDF, Word (.docx), PowerPoint (.pptx), plain text and Markdown** files up to 15 MB.
4. Wait for the progress bar to finish. The file shows **Ready** and how many passages were indexed (Figure 12).
5. Press **Chat with this document** to start asking questions, or **Summarize** for a summary.

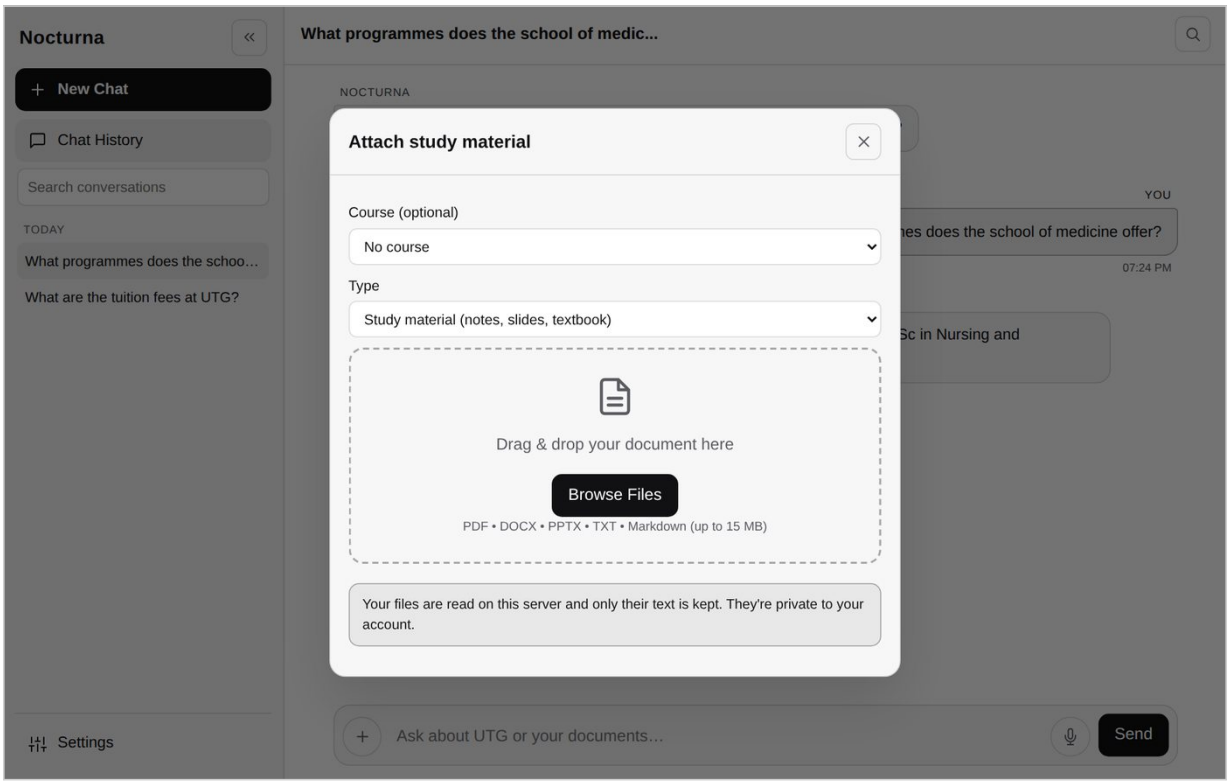


Figure 11: The upload window.

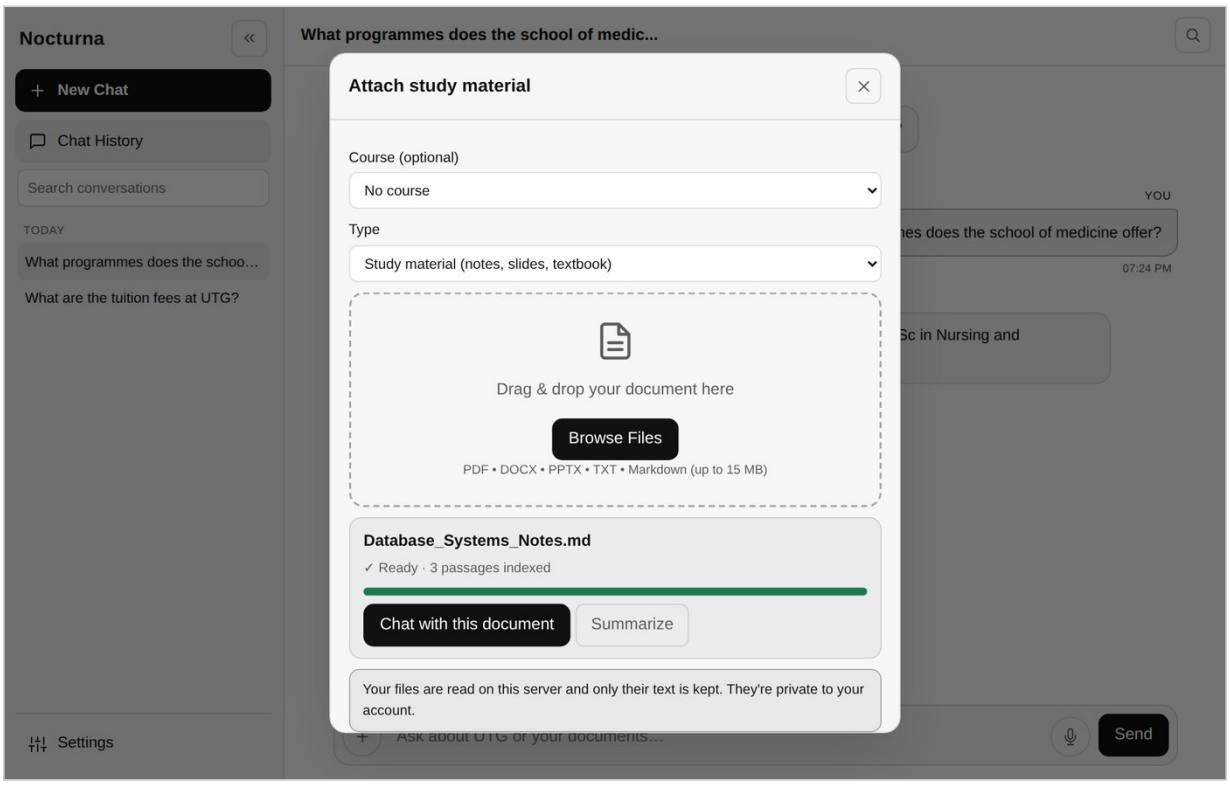


Figure 12: The document is ready: 3 passages indexed.

> **Privacy** Nocturna keeps only the extracted **text** of your document, never the original file. Scanned pages and photographs cannot be read because Nocturna has no text-recognition (OCR).

8. Asking about a document

1. Press **+** and choose **Ask about document**. The list of your documents opens (Figure 13).
2. Press **Ask questions** beside the document you want. A bar appears under the conversation title with the document name and the tabs *Overview, Chat, Summary, Quiz* and *Flashcards* (Figure 14).
3. Type your question. Nocturna replies with the most relevant passages from the document, **quoted exactly**, with the file name and section (Figure 15).
4. Press **Close document** in the bar to return to general questions.

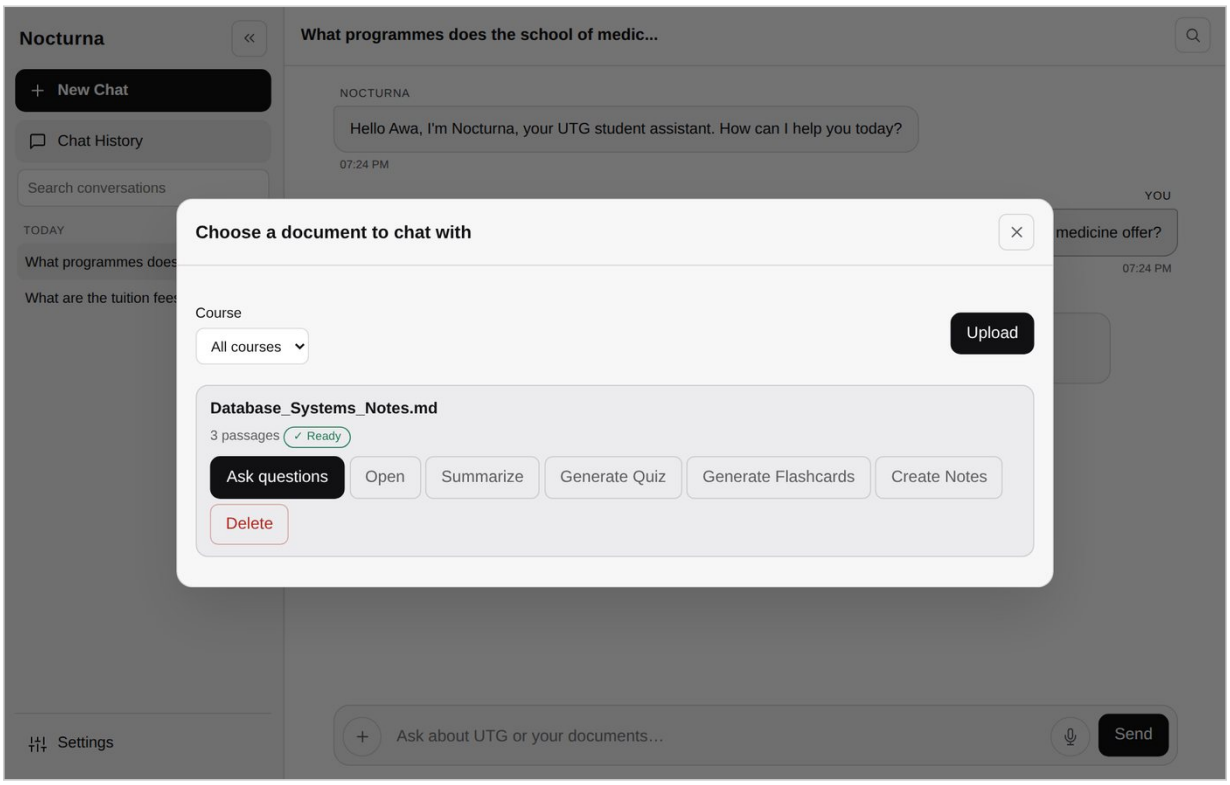


Figure 13: Choosing a document. Each document has buttons for questions, opening, summary, quiz, flashcards, notes and delete.

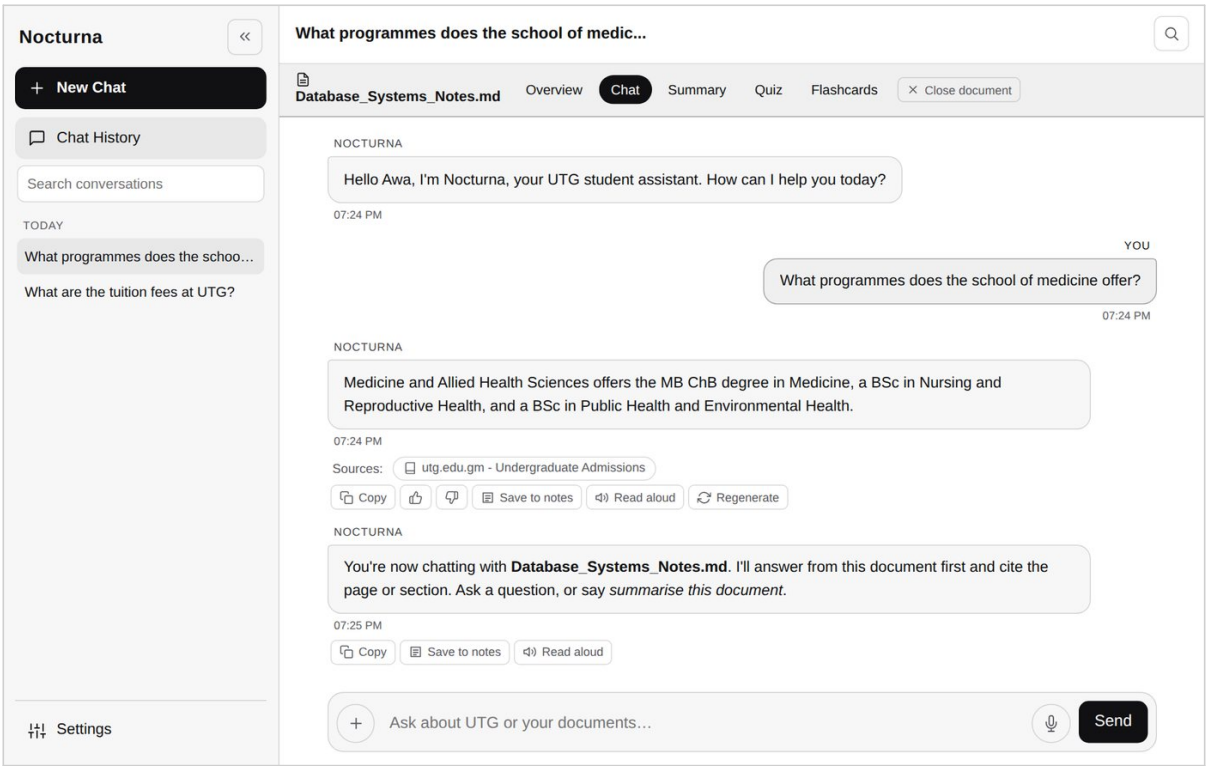


Figure 14: Chatting with a document: the document bar appears under the title.

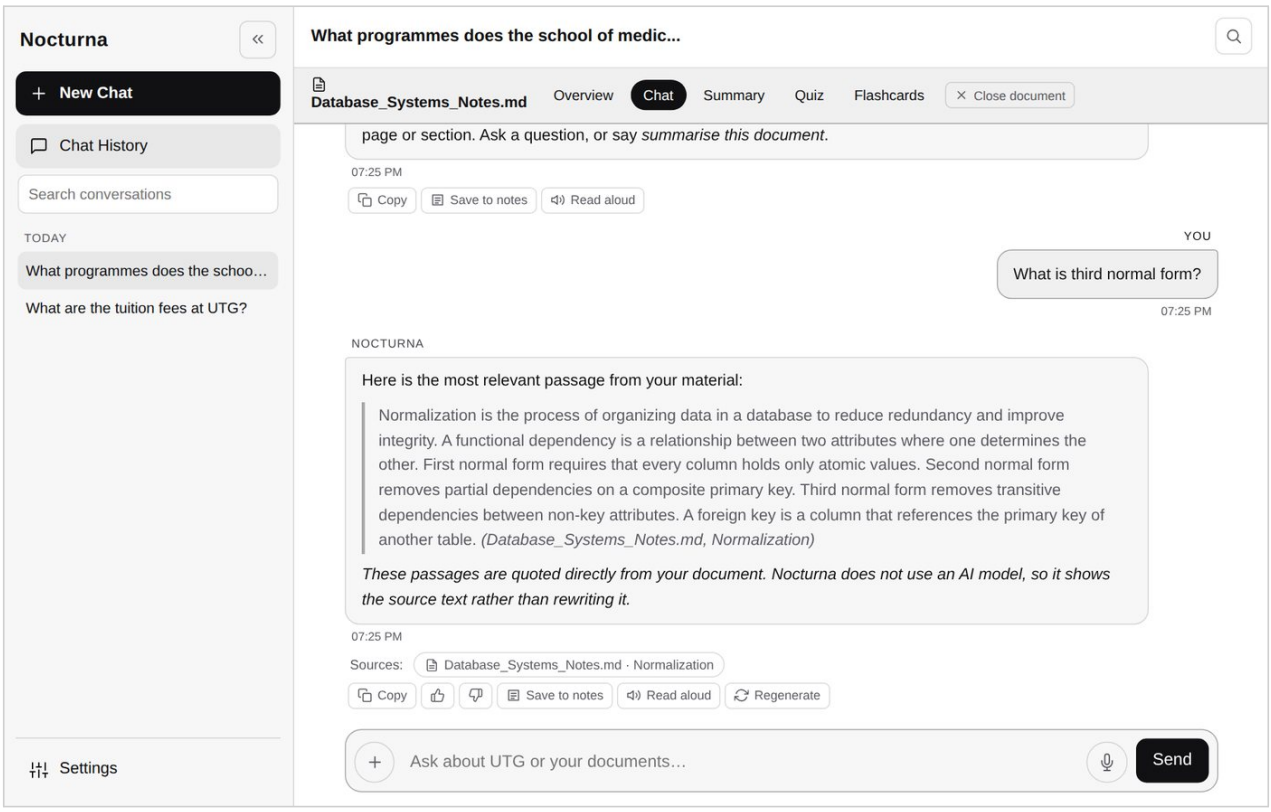


Figure 15: Answer quoted from the document, with the source shown below it.

Press **Open** on a document to see its overview (pages, passages and sections found), its summary and its full text. The **Ask about this** button beside a section starts a question about that section (Figure 16).

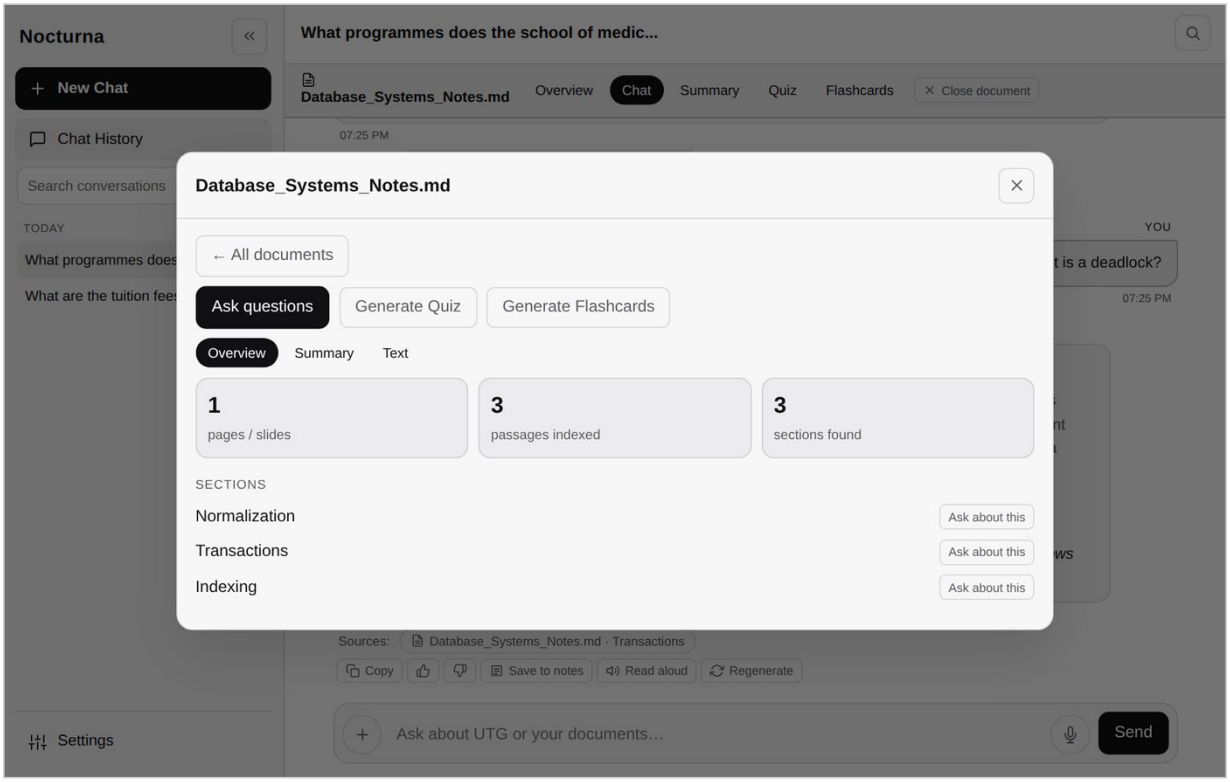


Figure 16: The document overview with its sections.

> **Why quotations?** Because Nocturna uses no AI model, it quotes your document instead of rewriting it. This keeps answers faithful to your own lecture notes. How many passages are shown, and how strict the matching is, can be changed in Settings (section 16.2).

9. Notes

1. Press **+** and choose **Create notes**. A blank note opens (Figure 17).
2. Type a **title**, optionally pick a course, and write your note in Markdown.
3. Press **Save** (Figure 18). Use **Preview** to see how it will look, and **Delete** to remove it.
4. Under *Turn this note into...* choose **Summary**, **Flashcards** or **Quiz** to build study material from the note.

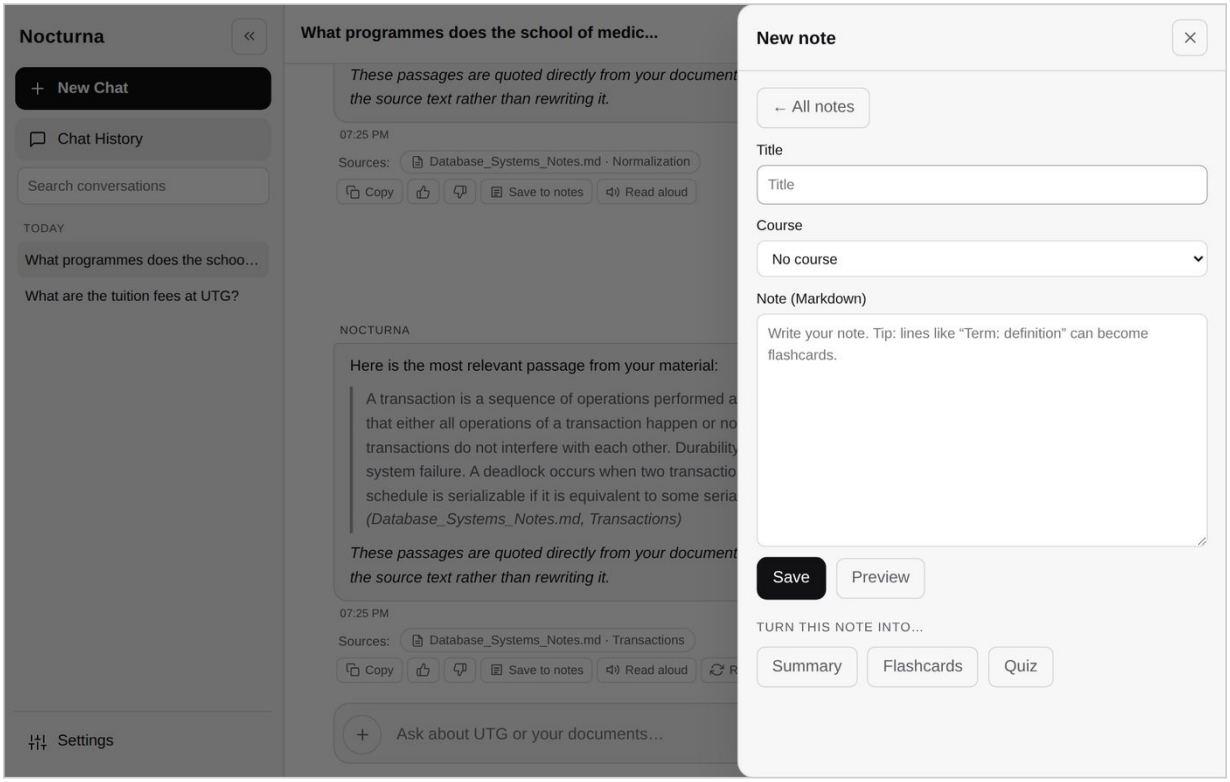


Figure 17: A blank note.

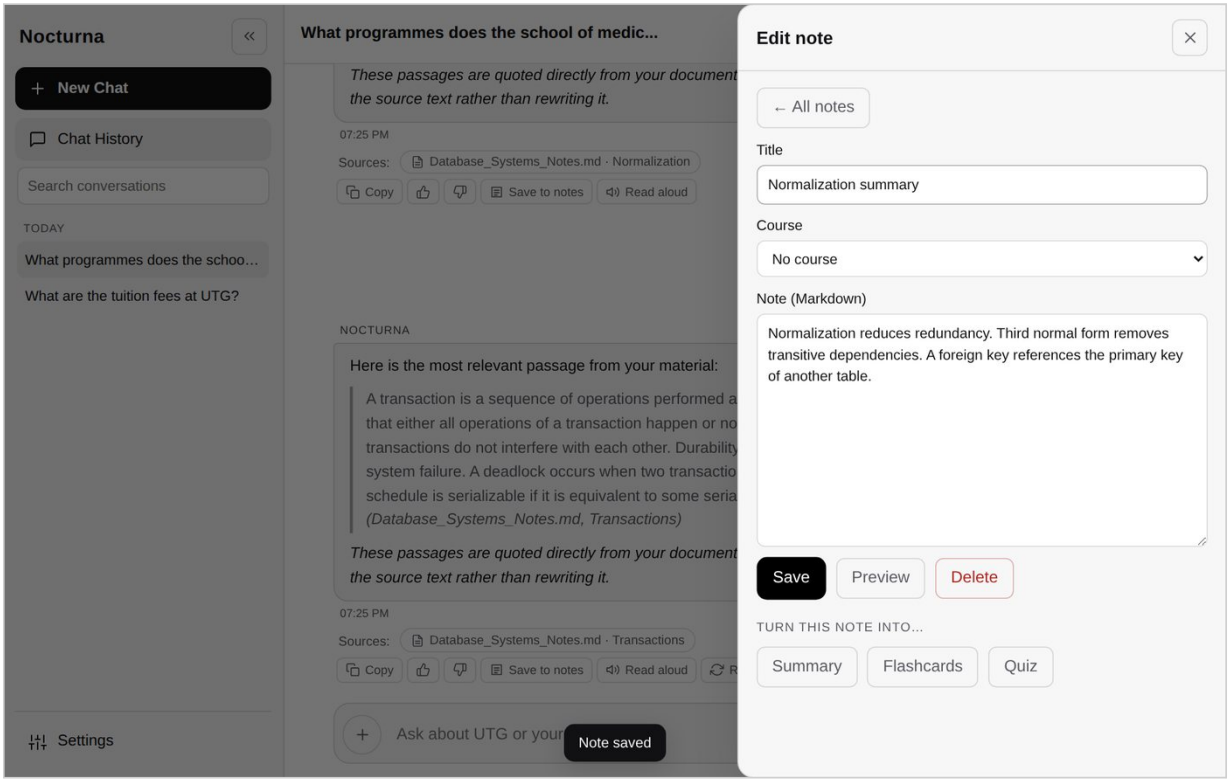


Figure 18: A saved note, with the options to turn it into a summary, flashcards or a quiz.

10. Quizzes

1. Press **+** and choose **Generate quiz** (Figure 19).
2. Choose what the quiz is made from: a **document**, a **course**, a **note**, a **topic**, **my weak topics** or **my past mistakes**.
3. Choose the number of questions, the difficulty (Easy, Medium, Hard) and the question types (multiple choice, true/false, short answer). Press **Generate quiz**.
4. Answer each question (Figure 20). Use the numbered buttons to jump between questions, **Flag** to mark one for review, and **Previous / Next** to move (Figure 21).
5. Press **Submit quiz**. Nocturna tells you how many questions are unanswered and asks you to confirm, because answers cannot be changed afterwards (Figure 22).
6. The results show your score, the topics that need improvement and recommended next steps, such as reviewing the section or studying flashcards (Figure 23).

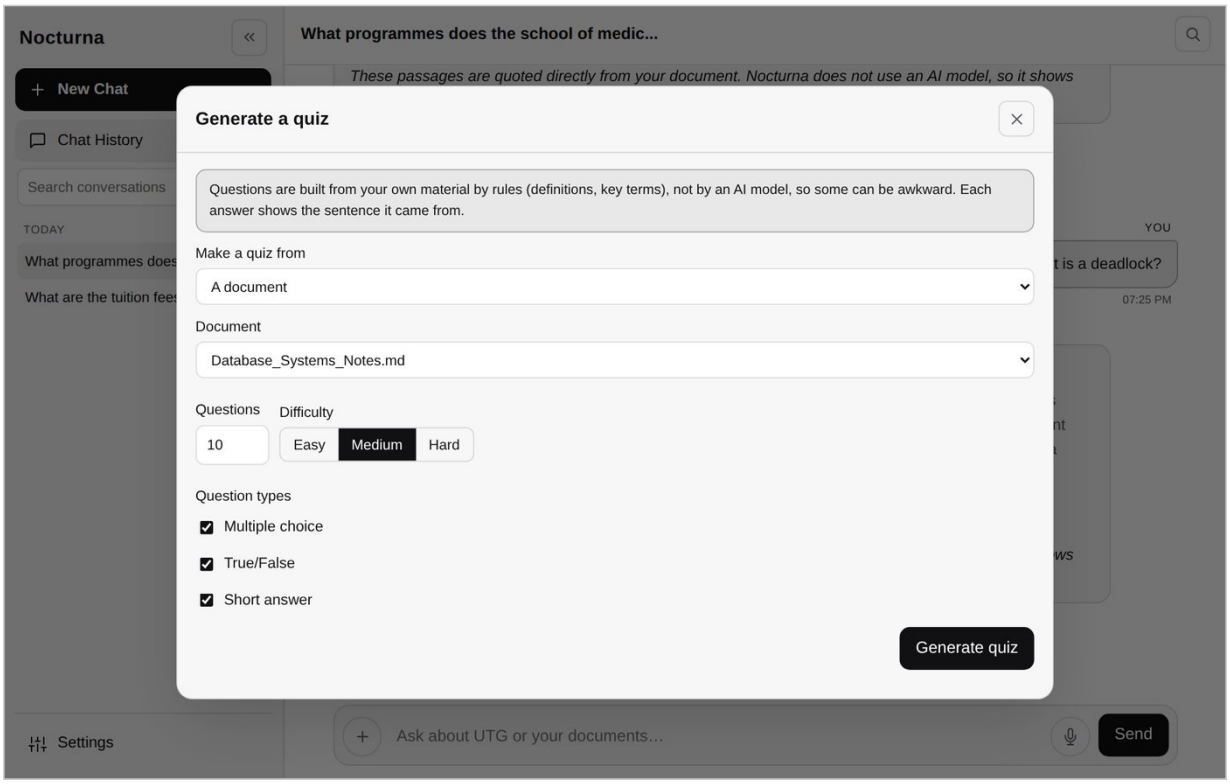


Figure 19: Quiz setup.

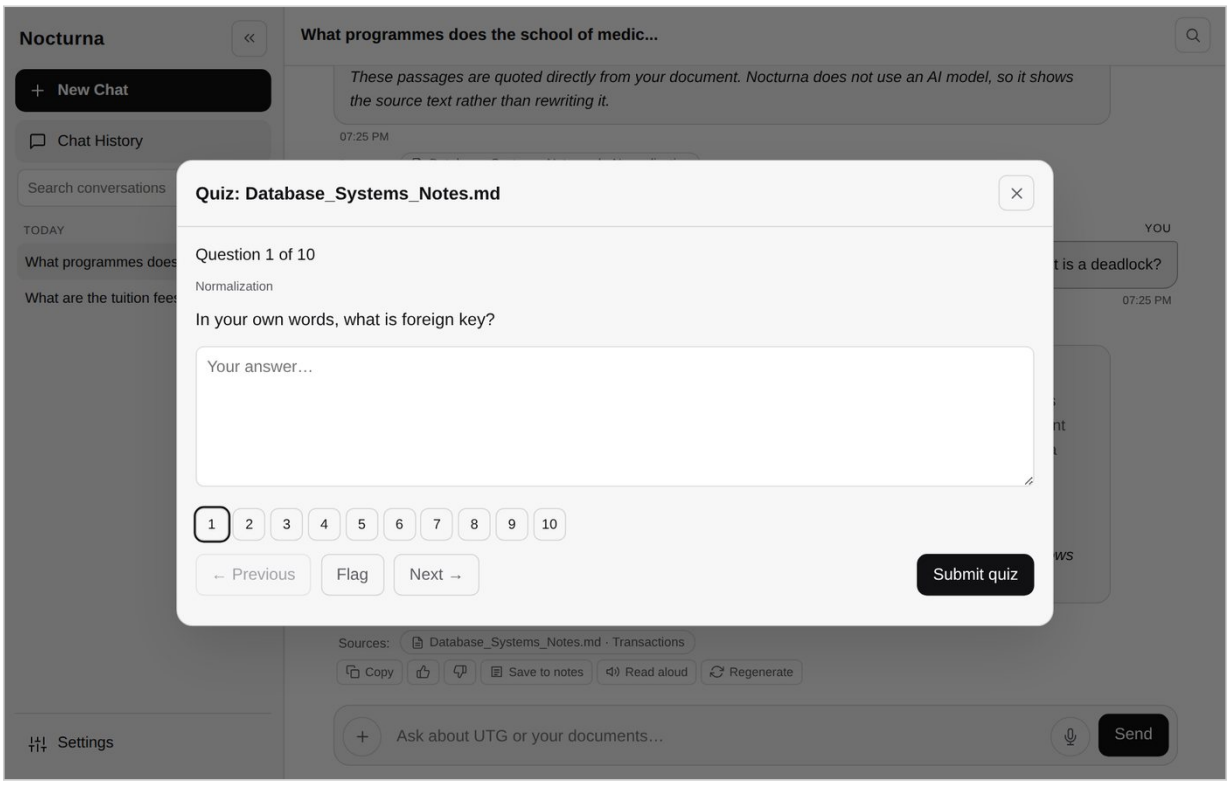


Figure 20: A quiz question.

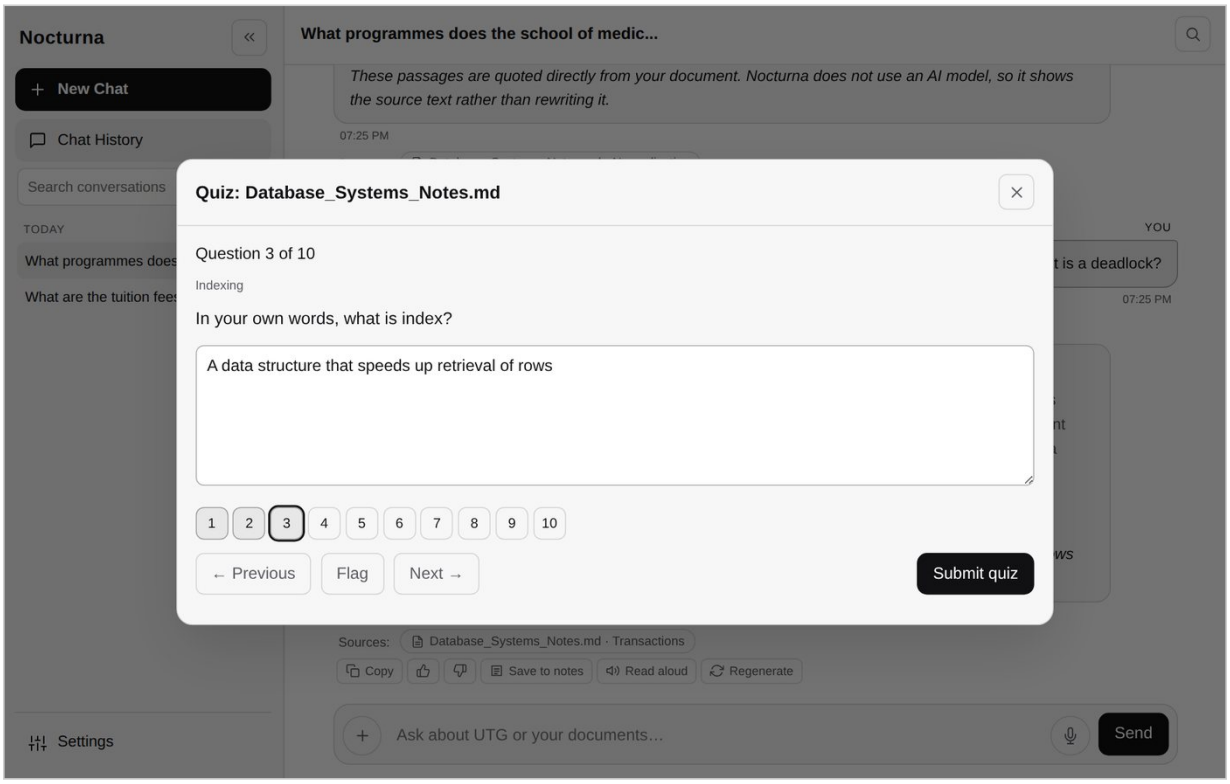


Figure 21: An answered question. The number buttons show your progress.

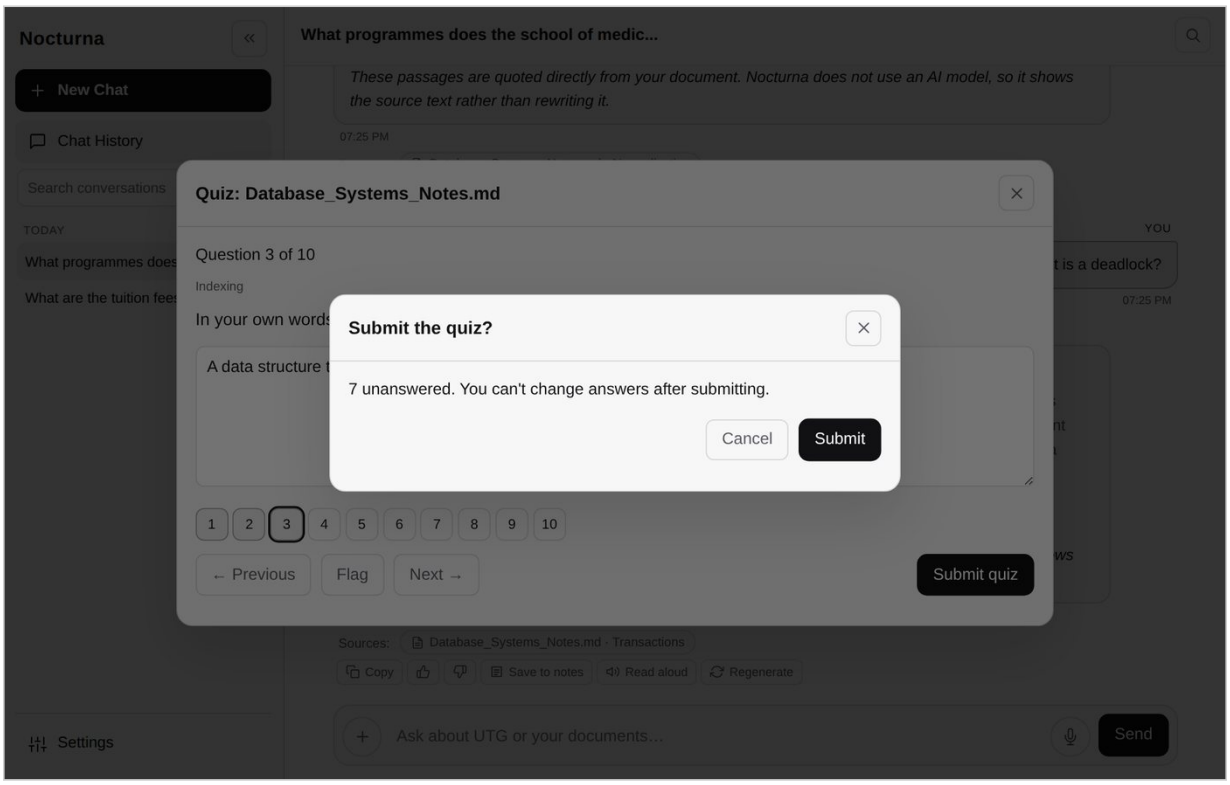


Figure 22: Confirming submission.

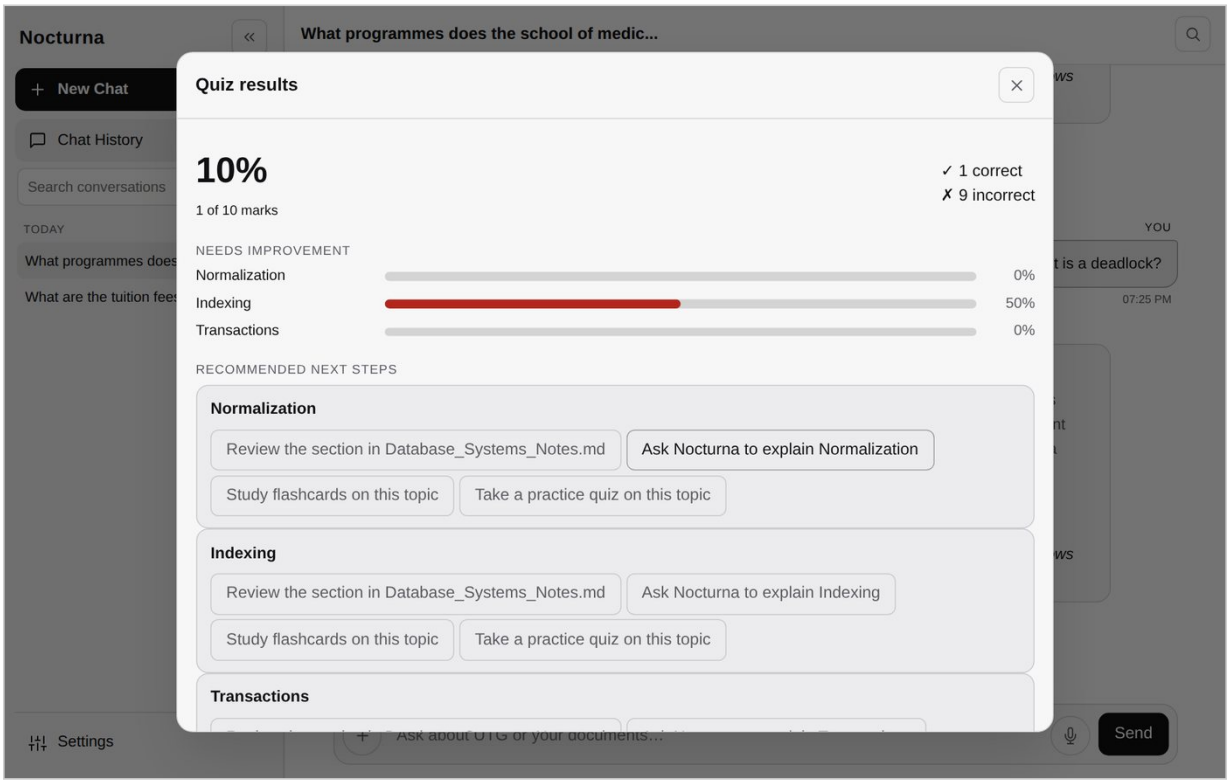


Figure 23: Quiz results with topics to improve and next steps.

> **Note** Questions are built by rules from your own material (definitions and key terms), not by an AI model, so a few may read awkwardly. Each answer shows the sentence it came from.

11. Flashcards

1. Press **+** and choose **Create flashcards** (Figure 24).

2. Choose the source (a document, a note or a topic) and how many cards to make, then press **Generate flashcards**. A message confirms how many were created.
3. Press **Study now** to review the cards that are due. Reveal the answer, then rate how well you knew it. Cards you find hard come back sooner.
4. You can also add your own card with a front (question) and back (answer) and the **Add** button.

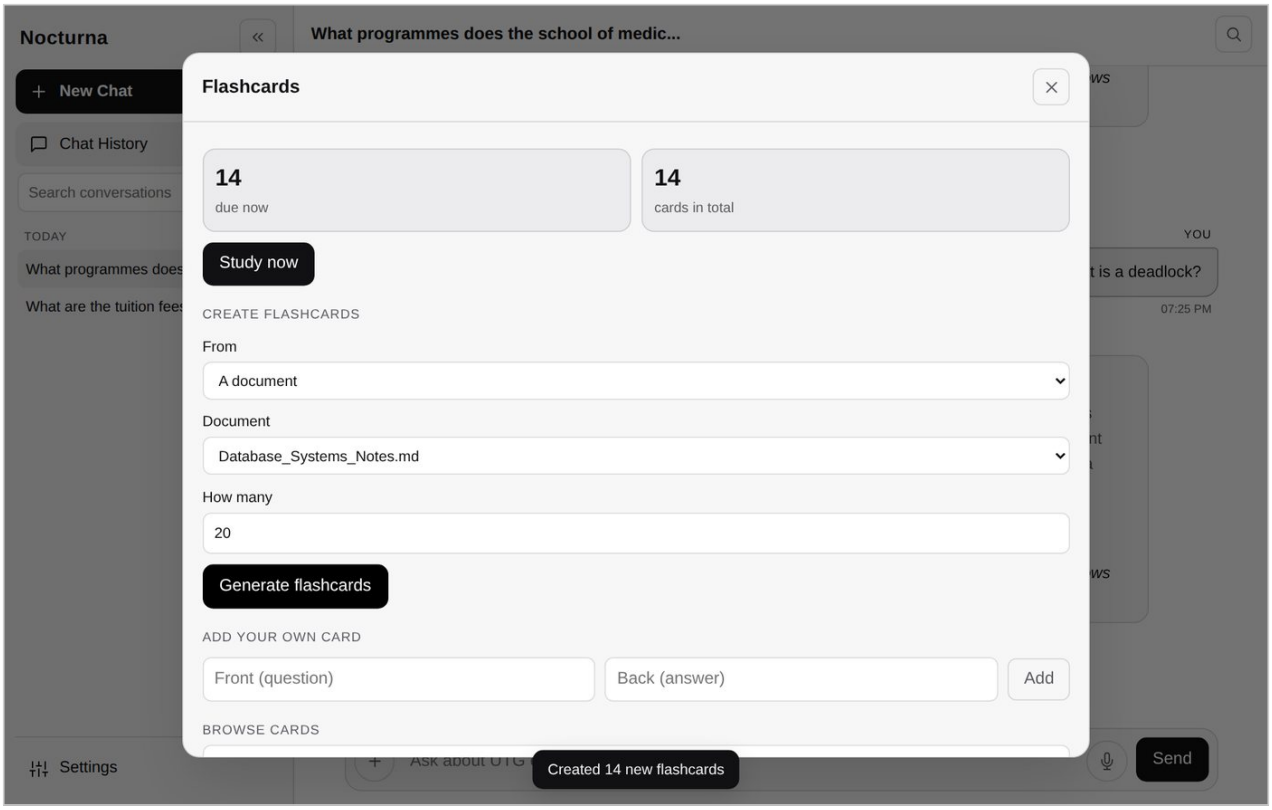


Figure 24: The flashcards window: cards due, total cards, and generation options.

12. Study plan

1. Press **+** and choose **Create study plan** (Figure 25).
2. Pick a course or type your **topics**, one per line. Enter your **exam date**, the **study hours per day** and your **current level**. Add *topics I struggle with* if you like (Figure 26).
3. Press **Create study plan**. Nocturna spreads your topics over the days before the exam and gives extra time to weak topics (Figure 27).
4. Tick each task off as you finish it. Press **Adapt to my results** to rebalance the plan after quizzes.

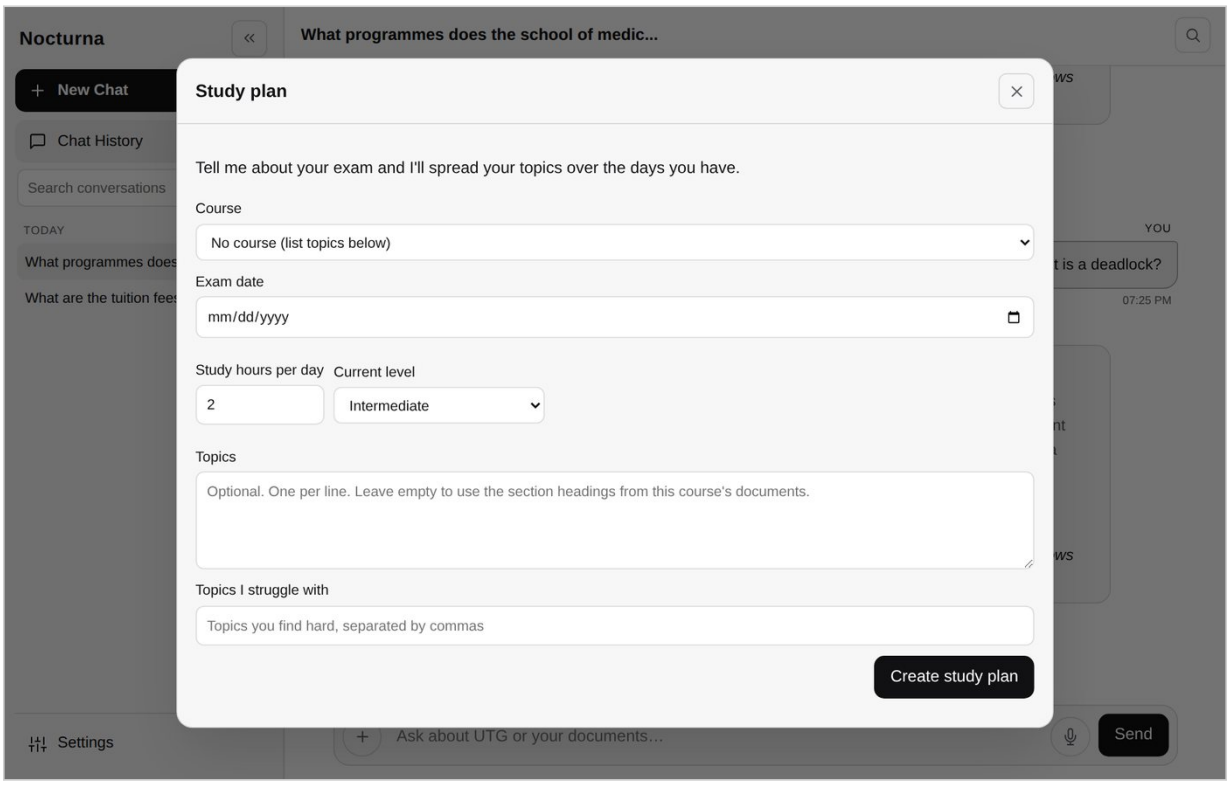


Figure 25: The study plan form.

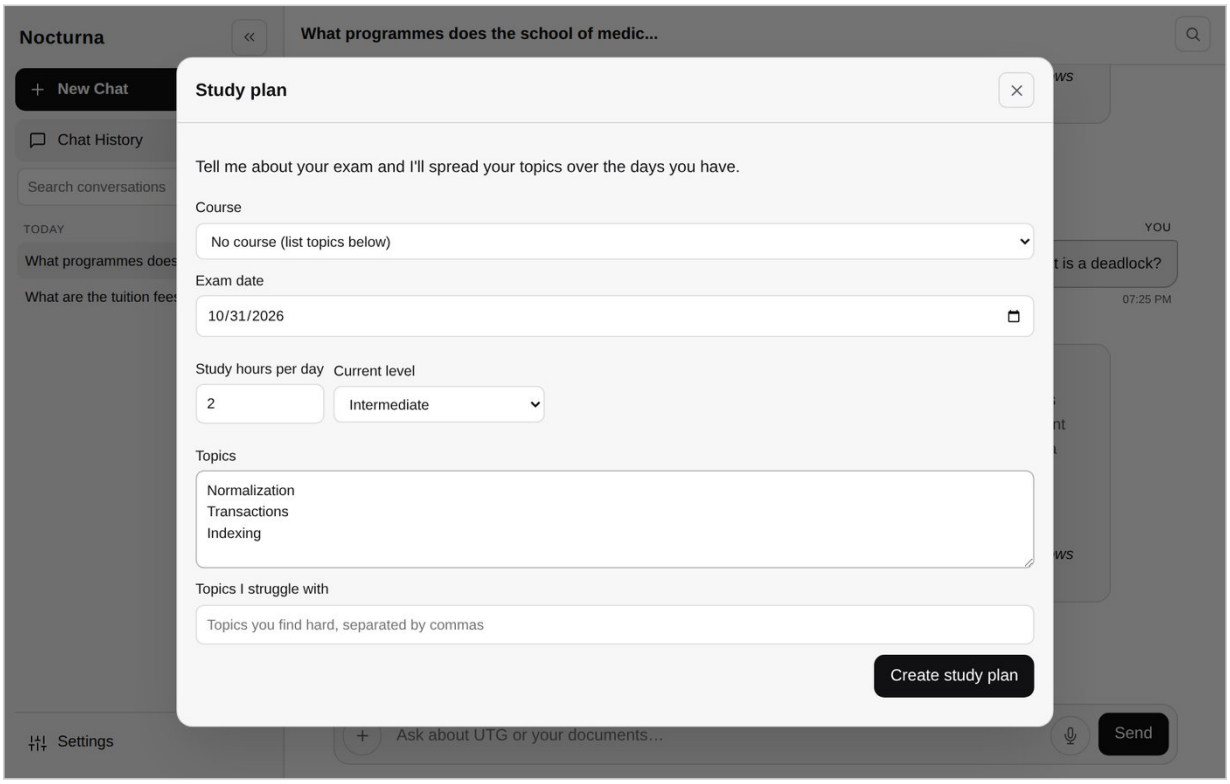


Figure 26: The form filled in with three topics and an exam date.

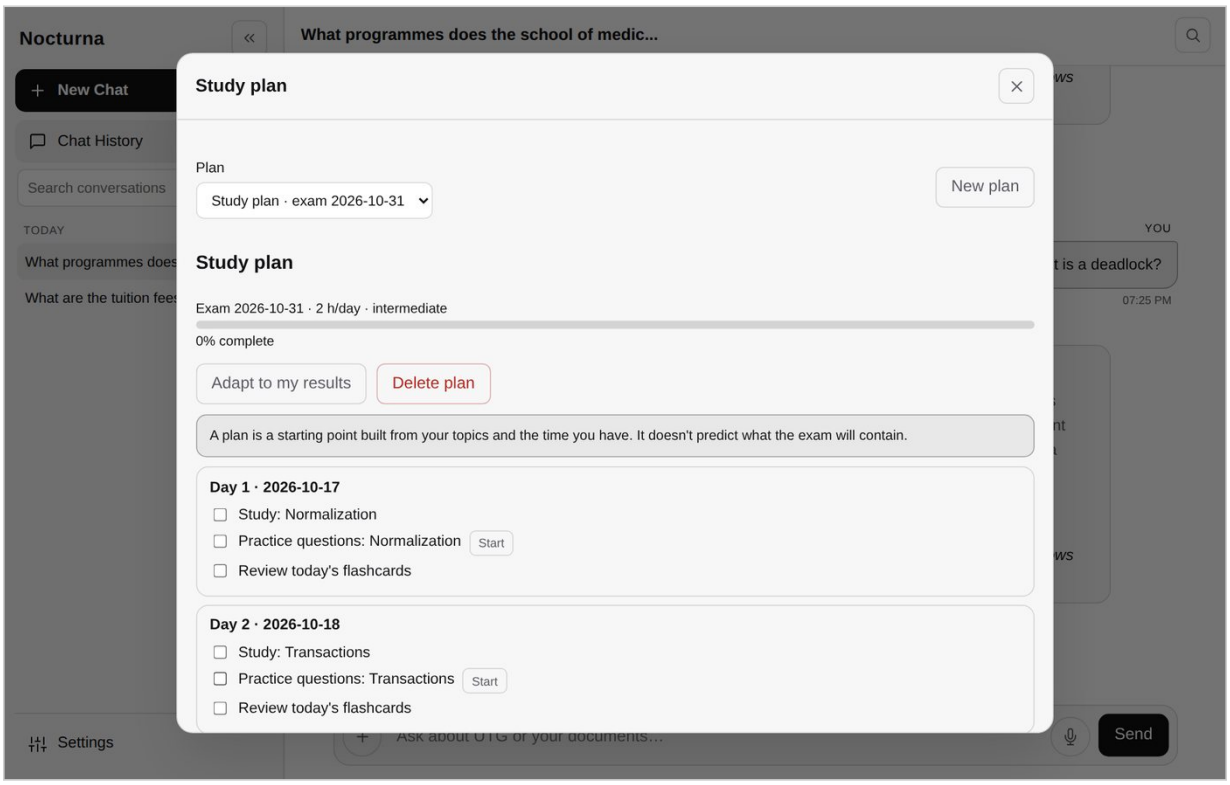


Figure 27: The generated plan with daily tasks.

> **Note** A plan is a starting point built from your topics and the time you have. It does not predict what the exam will contain.

13. Progress

Press **+** and choose **Show progress** (Figure 28). The window shows your study streak, average quiz score, quizzes taken, questions answered, flashcards reviewed and your mastery of each topic. A topic is flagged as weak when your score is below 60% after at least two answers. Recommendations at the bottom suggest what to do next.

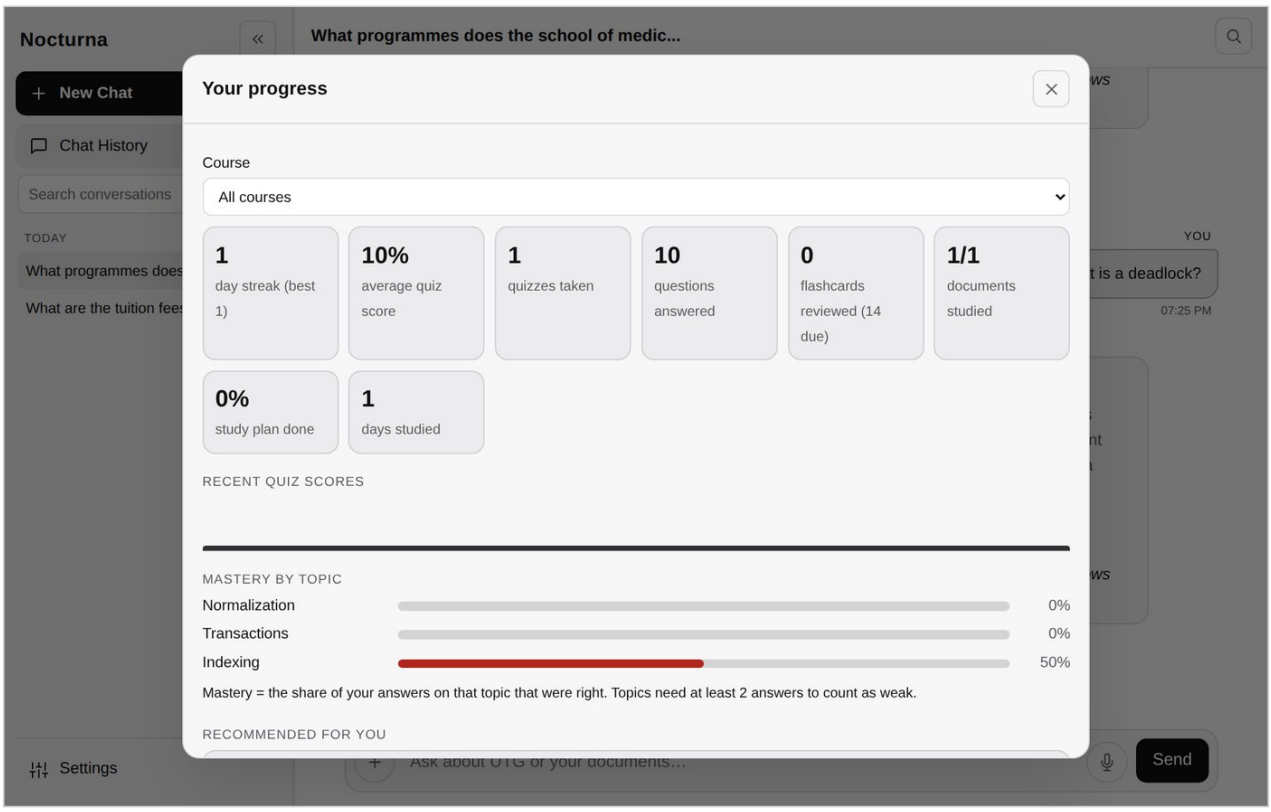


Figure 28: The progress window.

14. Past exam analyzer

Upload past exam papers as the type *Past exam paper* (section 7), then press **+** and choose **Analyze past exam** (Figure 29). Tick the papers to include and press **Analyze selected papers**. Nocturna counts which topics appear most often across the papers. The result always says 'frequently tested in the provided past papers' and is never a prediction of your exam.

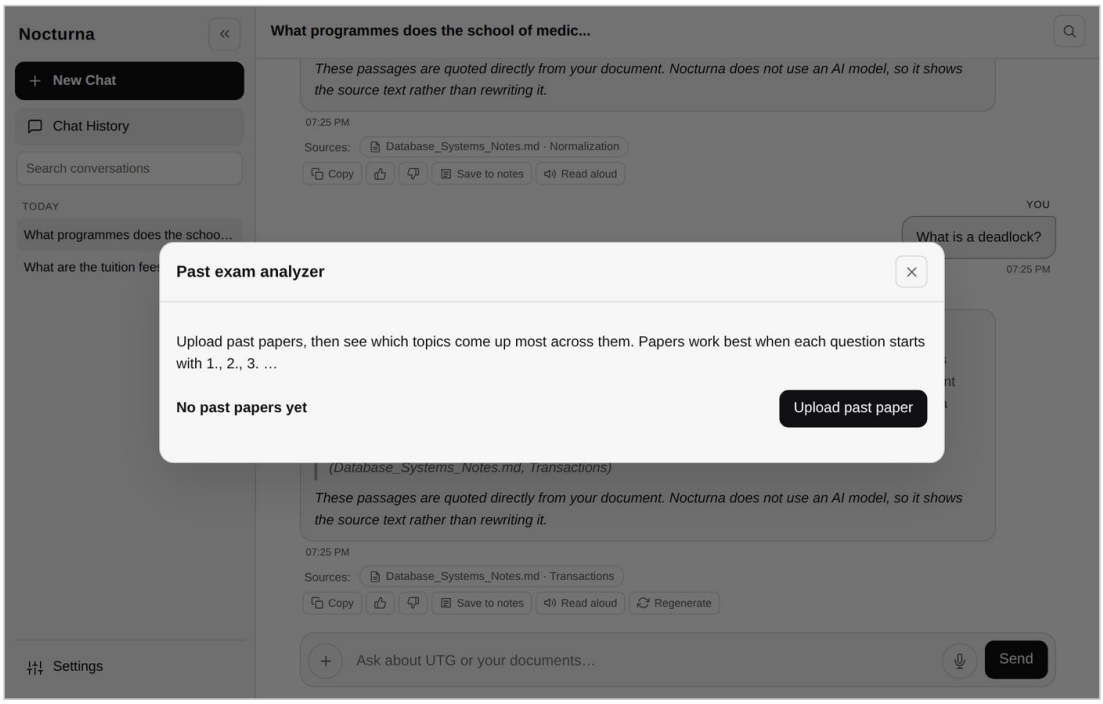


Figure 29: The past exam analyzer before any paper is uploaded.

15. Coding help and search

15.1 Coding help

1. Press **+** and choose **Coding help**.
2. Choose the language, paste your code and, if you have one, the error message (Figure 30). Press **Analyze**.
3. Nocturna explains what the error means, points to the line and column, and gives a hint (Figure 31).

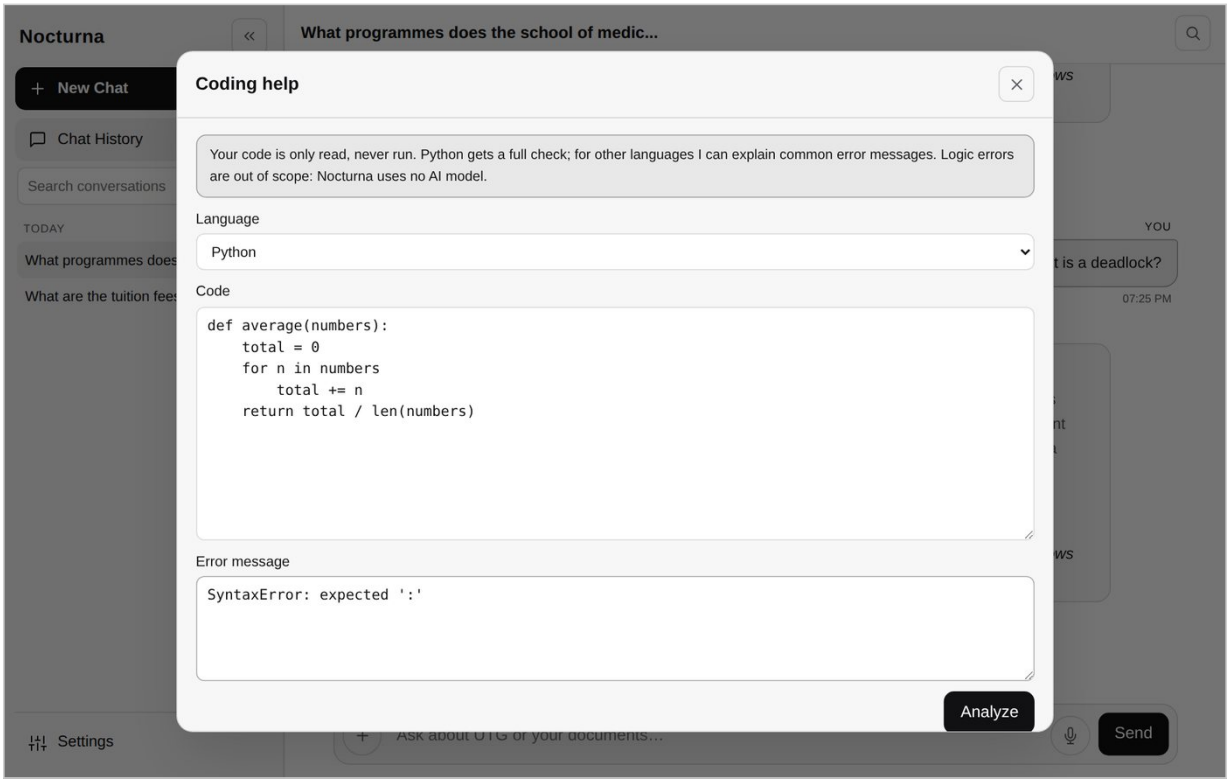


Figure 30: Code and error message entered.

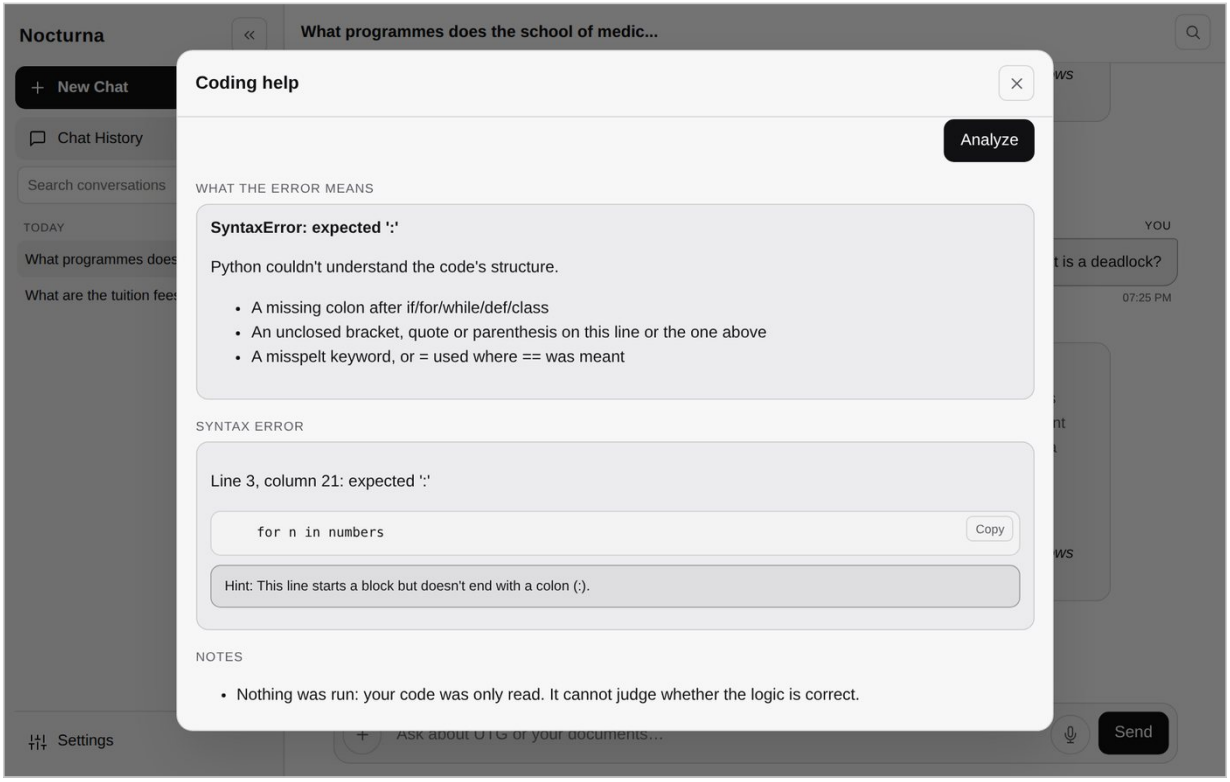


Figure 31: The explanation and the hint for the line with the problem.

> **Note** Your code is only **read**, never run. Python gets a full check. For other languages, paste the error message and Nocturna explains it. Nocturna cannot judge whether your logic is correct.

15.2 Search and commands

1. Press **Ctrl+K** or click the magnifying glass at the top right (Figure 32).
2. Type a word. Results are grouped into documents, conversations, notes, quiz questions and flashcards (Figure 33). Click a result to open it.
3. With the box empty, the list shows commands such as New chat, Upload study material, Generate a quiz and Show my progress. Press Esc to close.

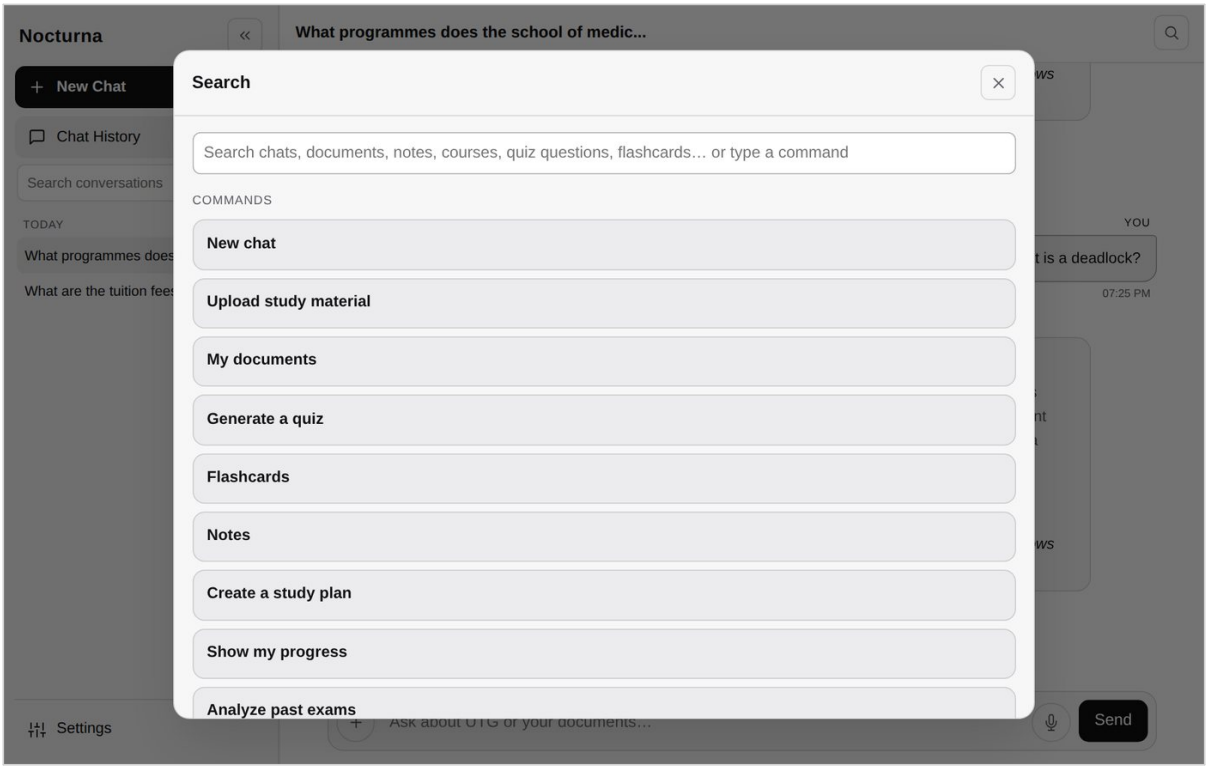


Figure 32: Search and command palette.

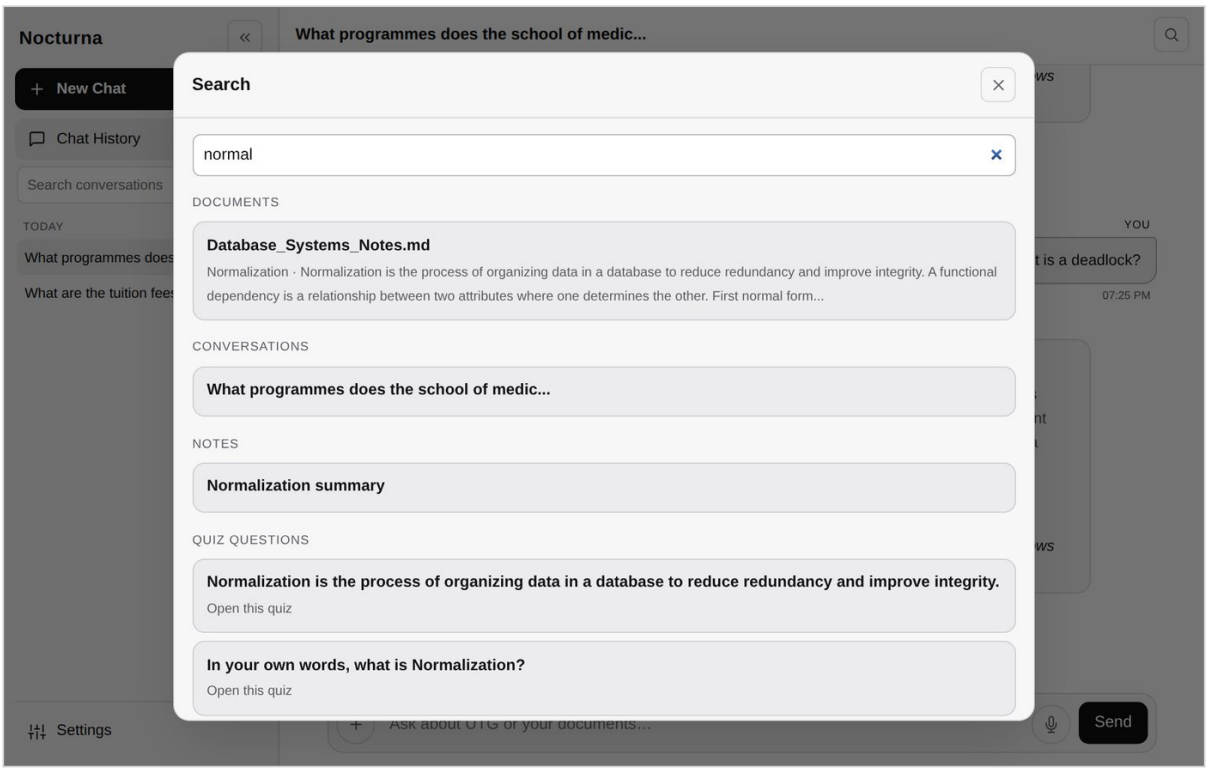


Figure 33: Search results for the word 'normal'.

16. Settings

Open **Settings** at the bottom of the sidebar. The window has three tabs: **General**, **Documents / RAG** and **User Profile / Account**. Click a tab, or use the left and right arrow keys, to move between them. Changes save as soon as you make them and a small 'Saved' message confirms it.

16.1 General

1. Open **Settings**. The **General** tab shows first (Figure 34).
2. Under **Theme** choose **Light** (white), **Dark** (black) or **System**. System follows your computer or phone and changes by itself when your device switches between day and night mode (Figure 35 shows the dark theme).
3. Tick or untick **Show timestamps** to show or hide the time under every message (Figure 36 shows the chat with timestamps off, Figure 37 the dark theme in the chat).

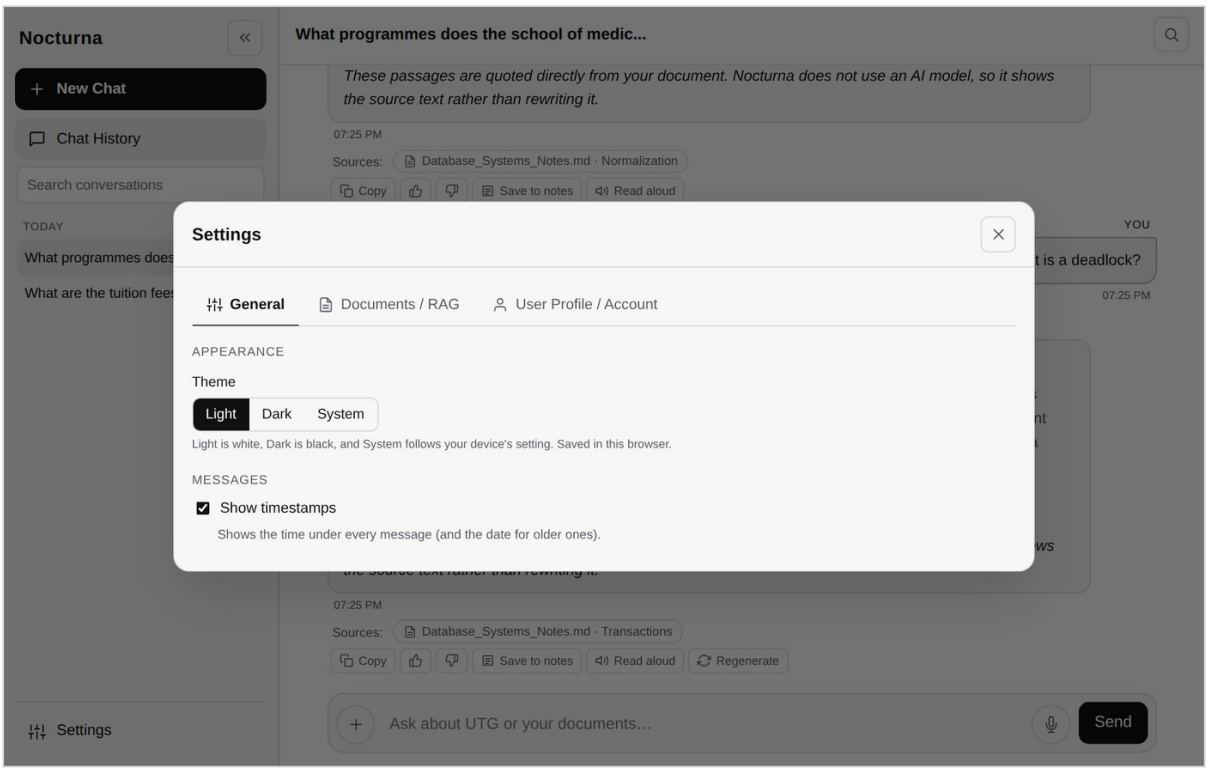


Figure 34: Settings, General tab.

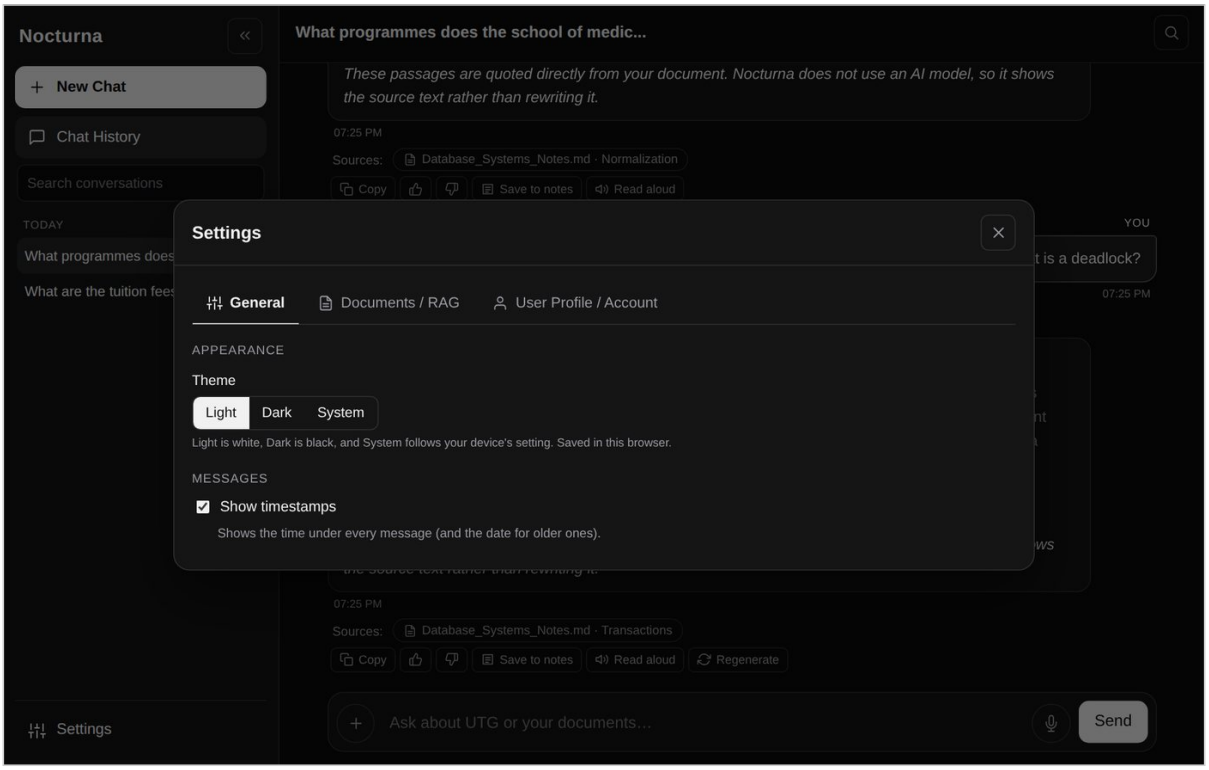


Figure 35: The dark (black) theme.

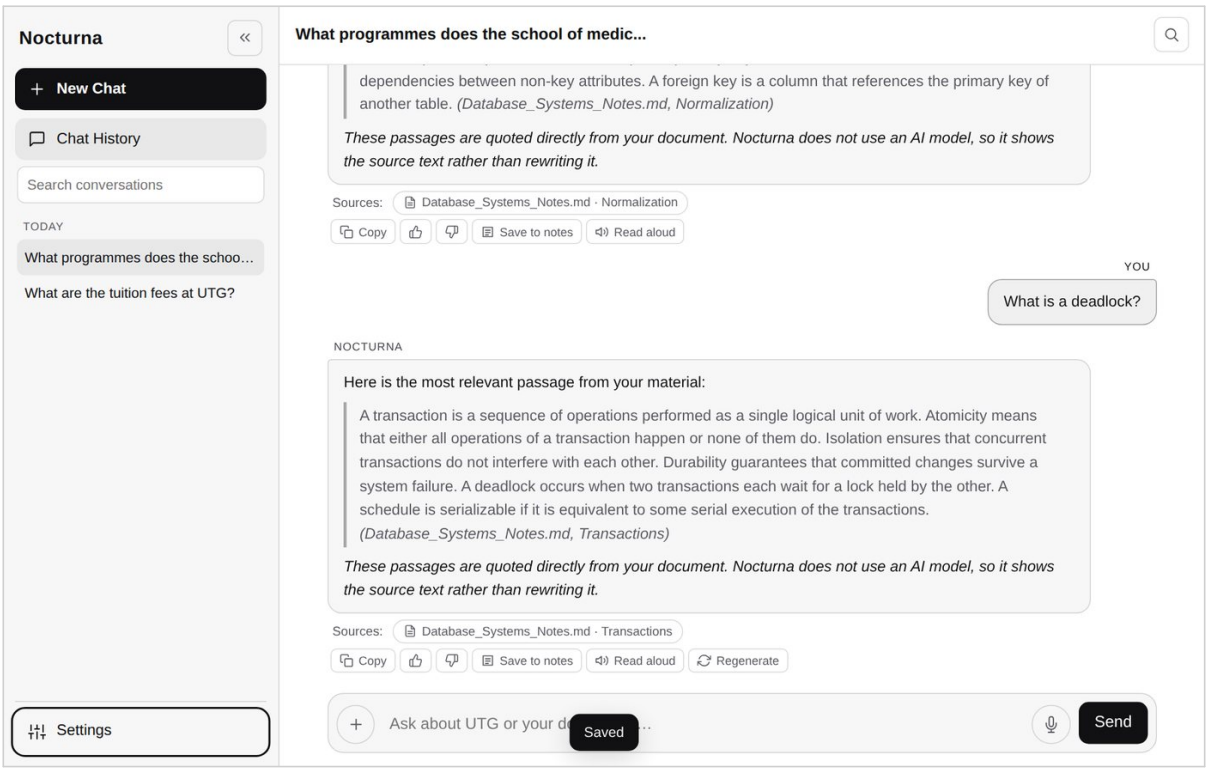


Figure 36: Timestamps switched off: no times under the messages.

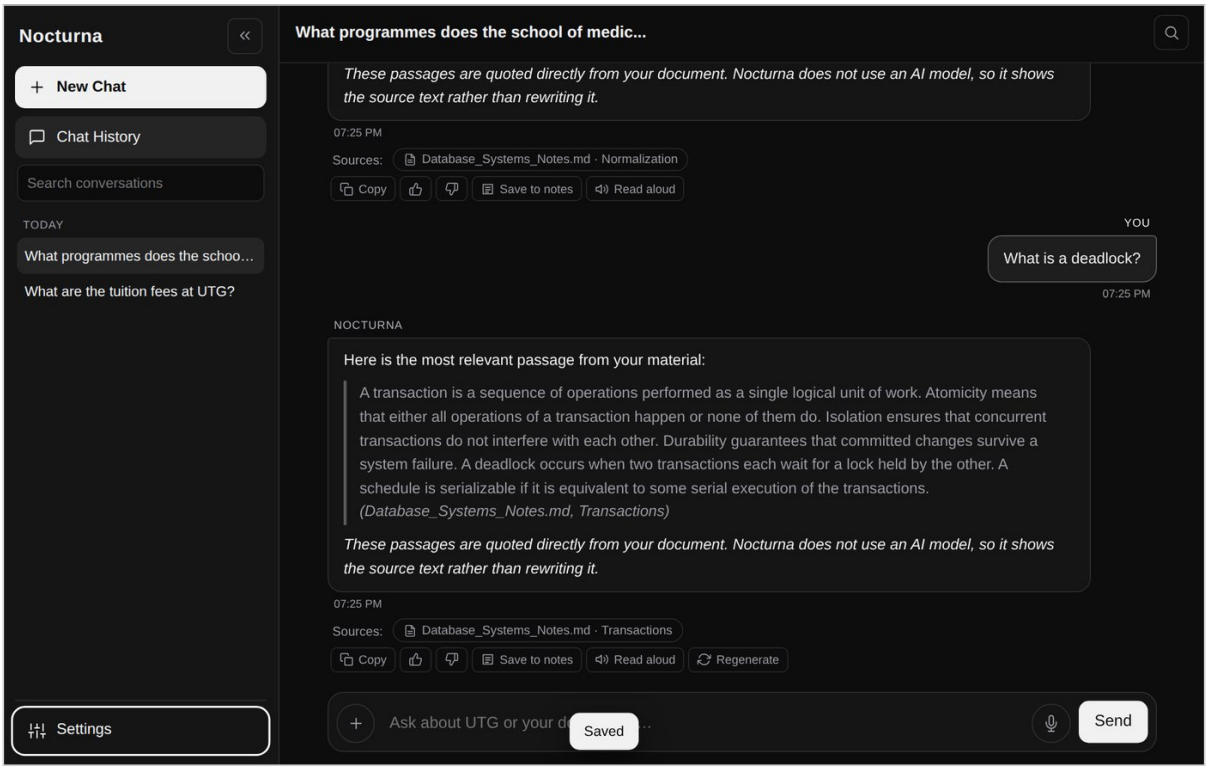


Figure 37: The chat in the dark theme with timestamps on.

> **Note** Your theme choice is remembered in this browser, even after you log out.

16.2 Documents / RAG

RAG means *retrieval-augmented answers*. In Nocturna it means that answers are **retrieved** from your documents. They are not generated by an AI. This tab controls how that retrieval works (Figure 38).

Setting	What it does
Passages per answer	How many matching passages Nocturna quotes: 1 to 5 (default 3).
Search strictness	*Relaxed* shows more passages, some only loosely related. *Balanced* is the default. *Strict* shows only close matches.
Show sources under answers	Shows the document, page and section for each answer.
Search my documents when UTG information has no answer	On: a general question the UTG knowledge base cannot answer is checked against your documents. Off: your documents are searched only when you have opened one in the chat.

Under **Document library** (Figure 39) you can see how many documents you have, how many are indexed and how many passages that is. The buttons **Upload a document**, **Manage documents** and **Delete all my documents** do what they say; deleting all documents needs you to type DELETE first and leaves your notes, quizzes and chats untouched. Under **My courses** you can add, rename and delete courses, which group your documents, notes and plans.

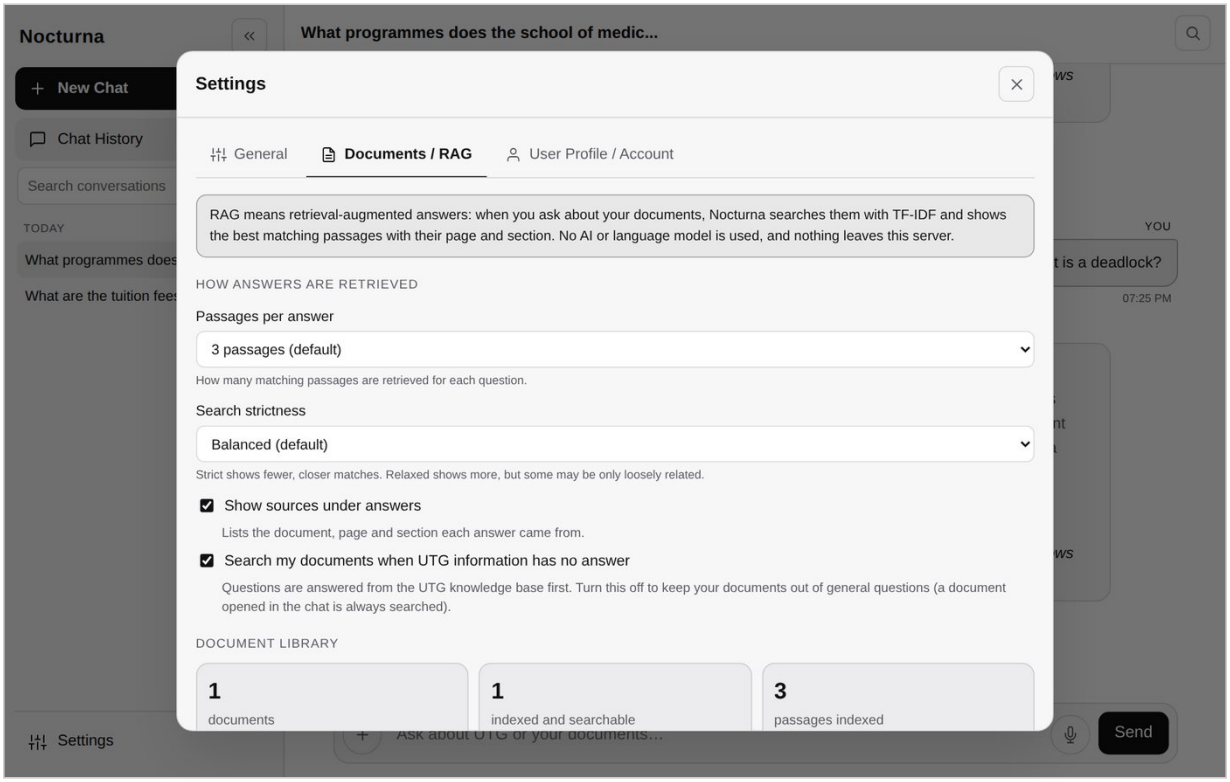


Figure 38: Settings, Documents / RAG tab.

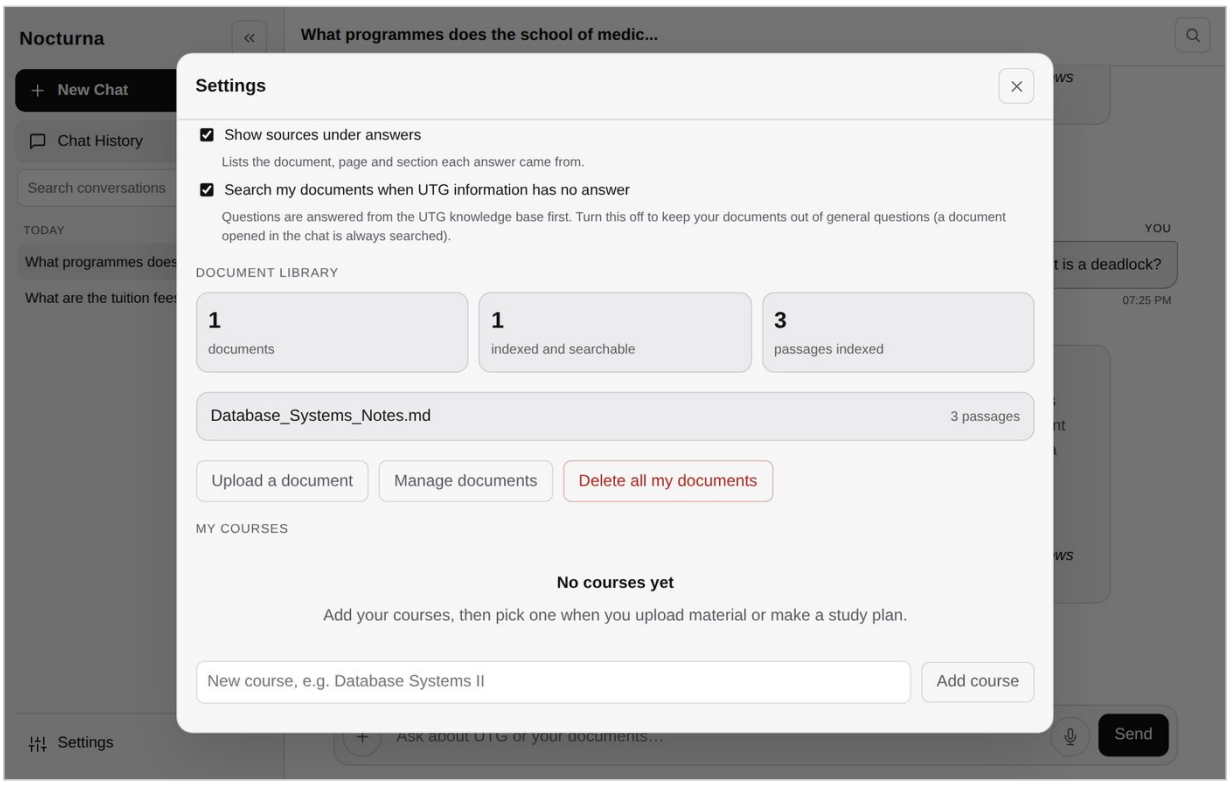


Figure 39: The document library and My courses.

16.3 User Profile / Account

- **Profile:** change your name, study goals and learning preferences and press **Save profile**. Your UTG email is your login and cannot be changed here (Figure 40).
- **Password:** enter your current password and a new one of at least 8 characters, then press **Change password**.
- **Privacy and data** (Figure 41): a plain description of what is kept. **Download my data** saves everything stored about you as one file. **Delete all my notes** and **Delete quizzes, flashcards and progress** remove those items after you type DELETE to confirm.
- **Chat history: Clear chat history** deletes every conversation.
- **Account: Log out**, or **Delete my account**.

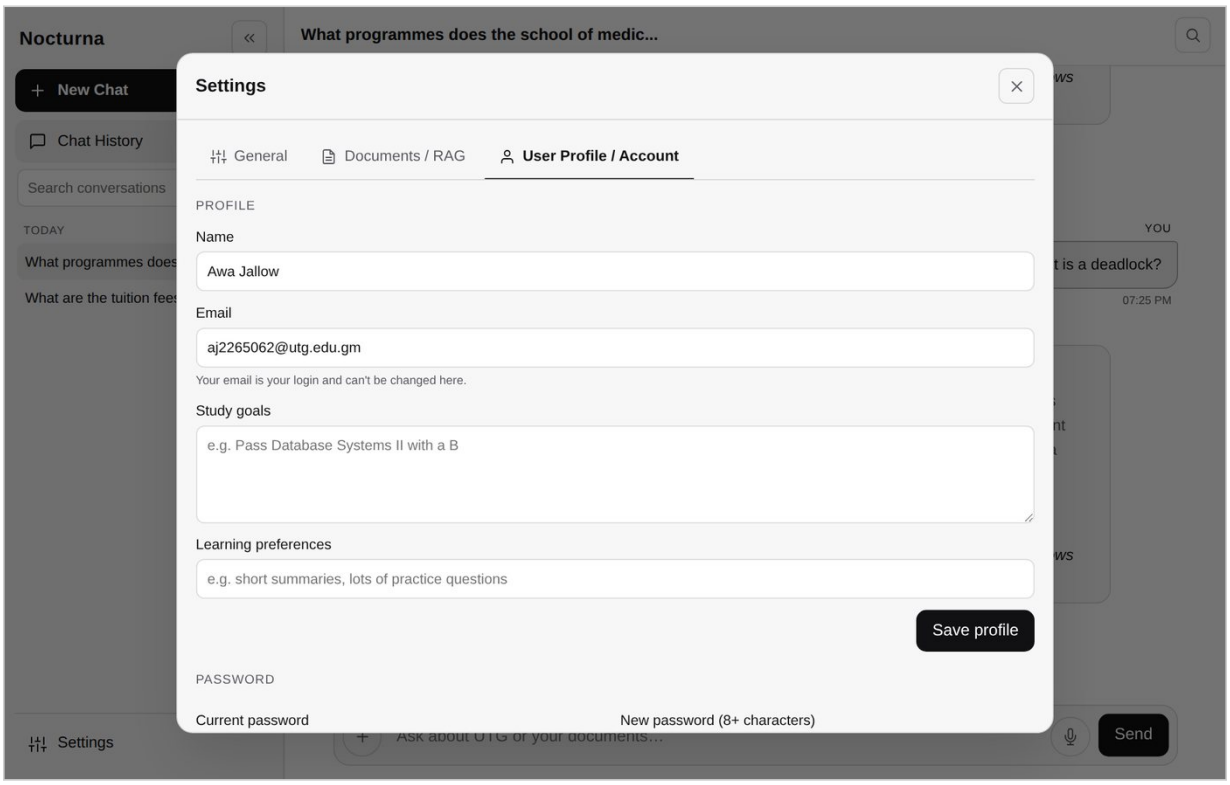


Figure 40: Settings, User Profile / Account tab: profile.

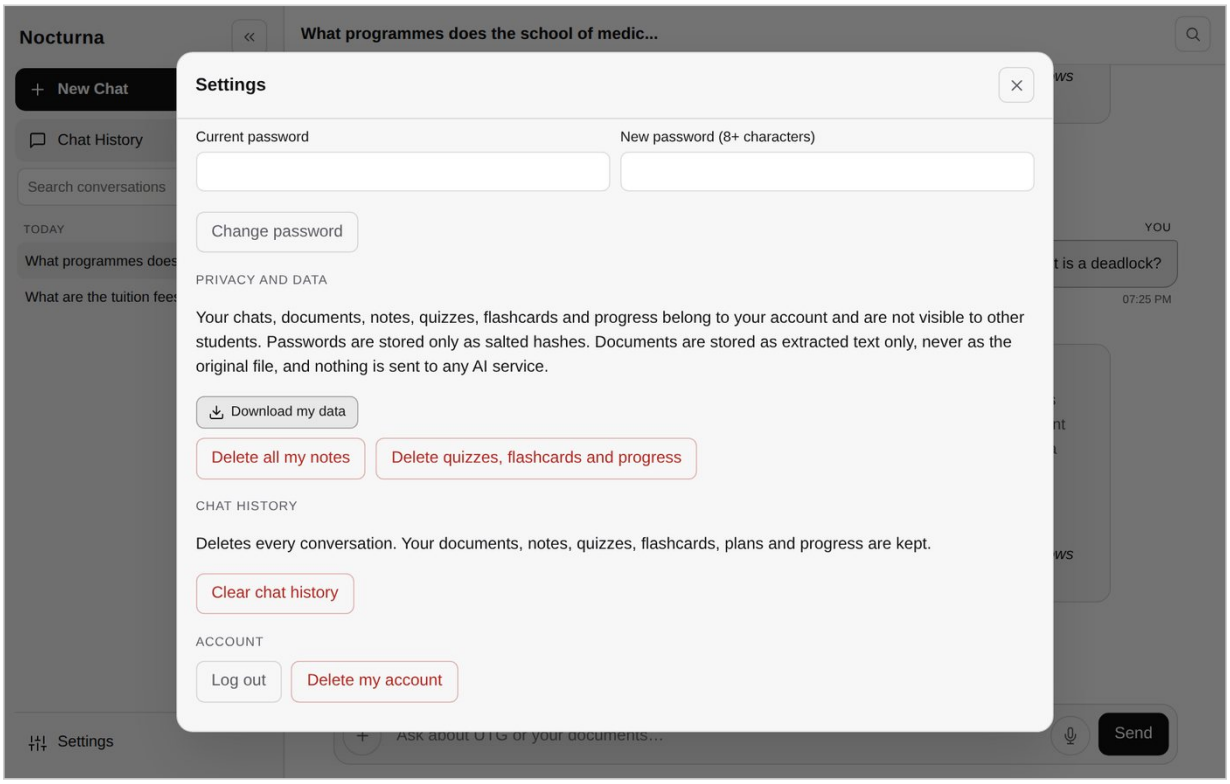


Figure 41: Password, privacy and data, chat history and account controls.

16.4 Clearing your chat history

1. Open **Settings**, then the **User Profile / Account** tab, and press **Clear chat history**.
2. A window asks 'Clear all chat history?' (Figure 42). It explains that your documents, notes, quizzes, flashcards, plans and progress are kept. Press **Clear history** to confirm or **Cancel**.
3. Your conversations are removed and a fresh chat opens (Figure 43).

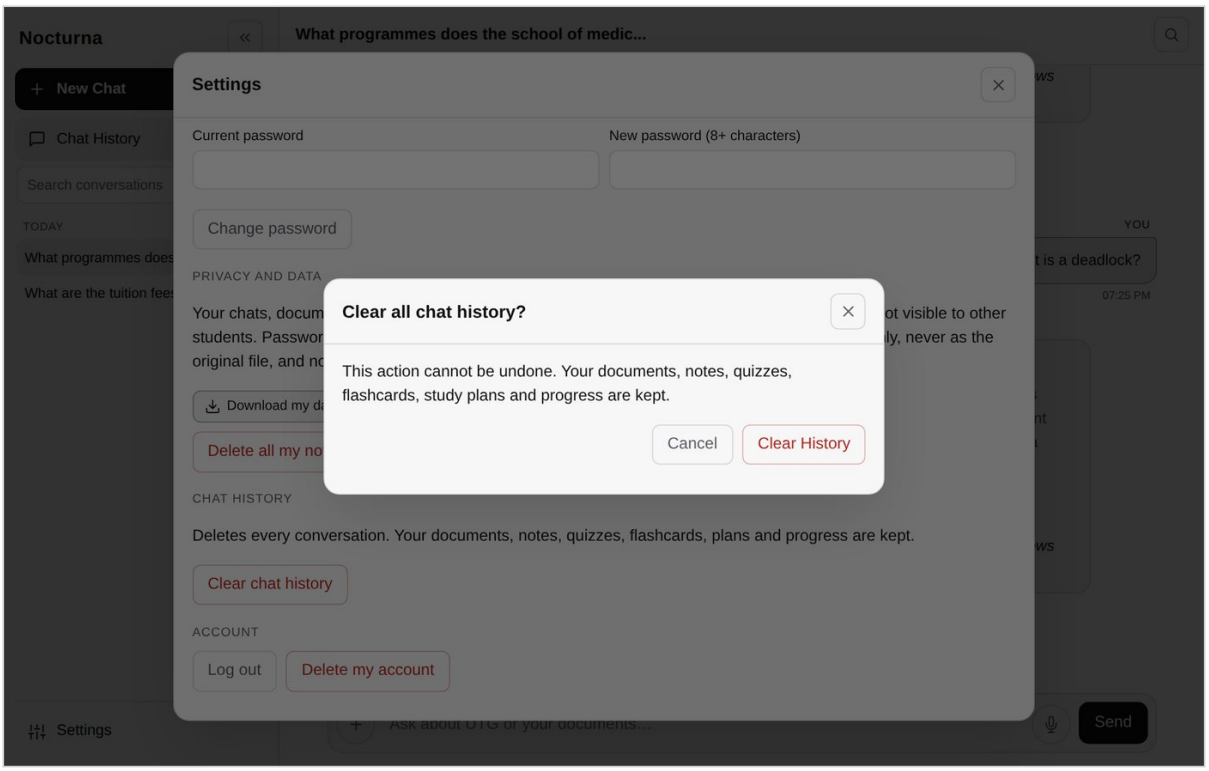


Figure 42: Confirming that chat history should be cleared.

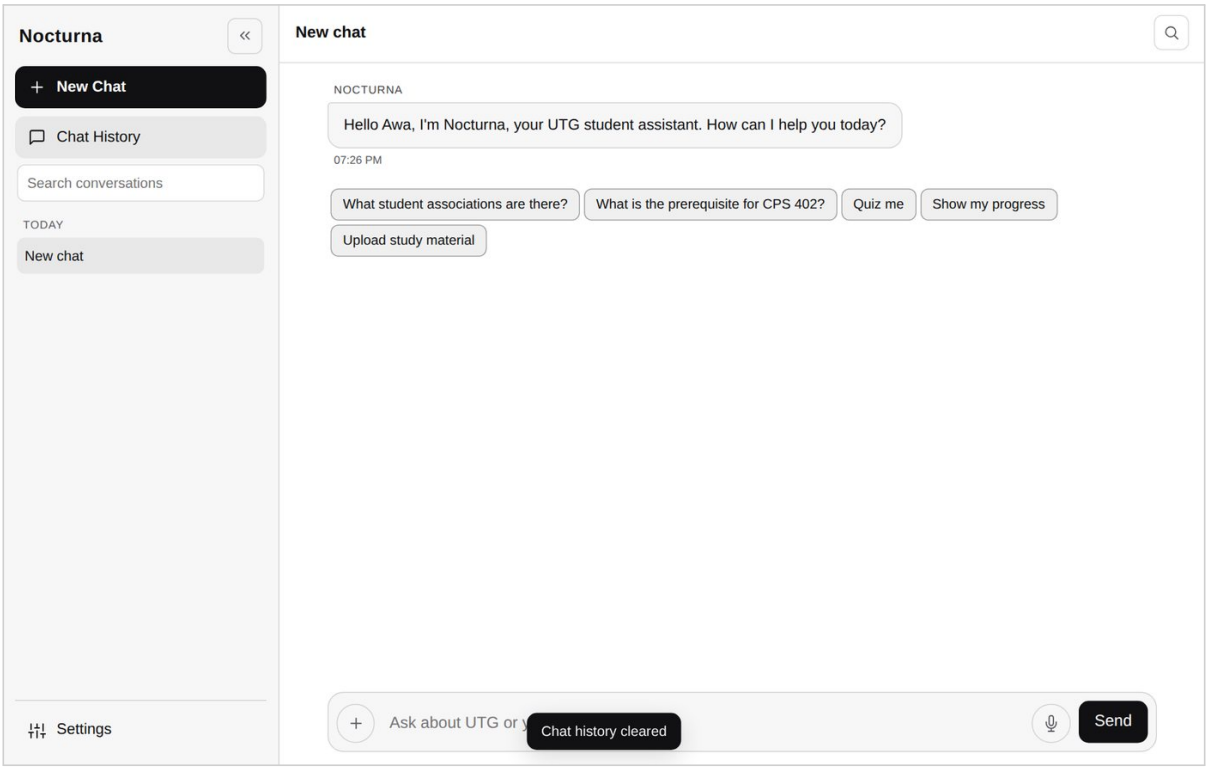


Figure 43: After clearing: an empty history and a new chat.

16.5 Deleting your account

1. Open **Settings**, then the **User Profile / Account** tab, and press **Delete my account**.
2. Enter your **password** and type **DELETE** in the confirmation box (Figure 44).
3. Press **Delete everything**. Your account and all your data are permanently removed and you are returned to the login page.

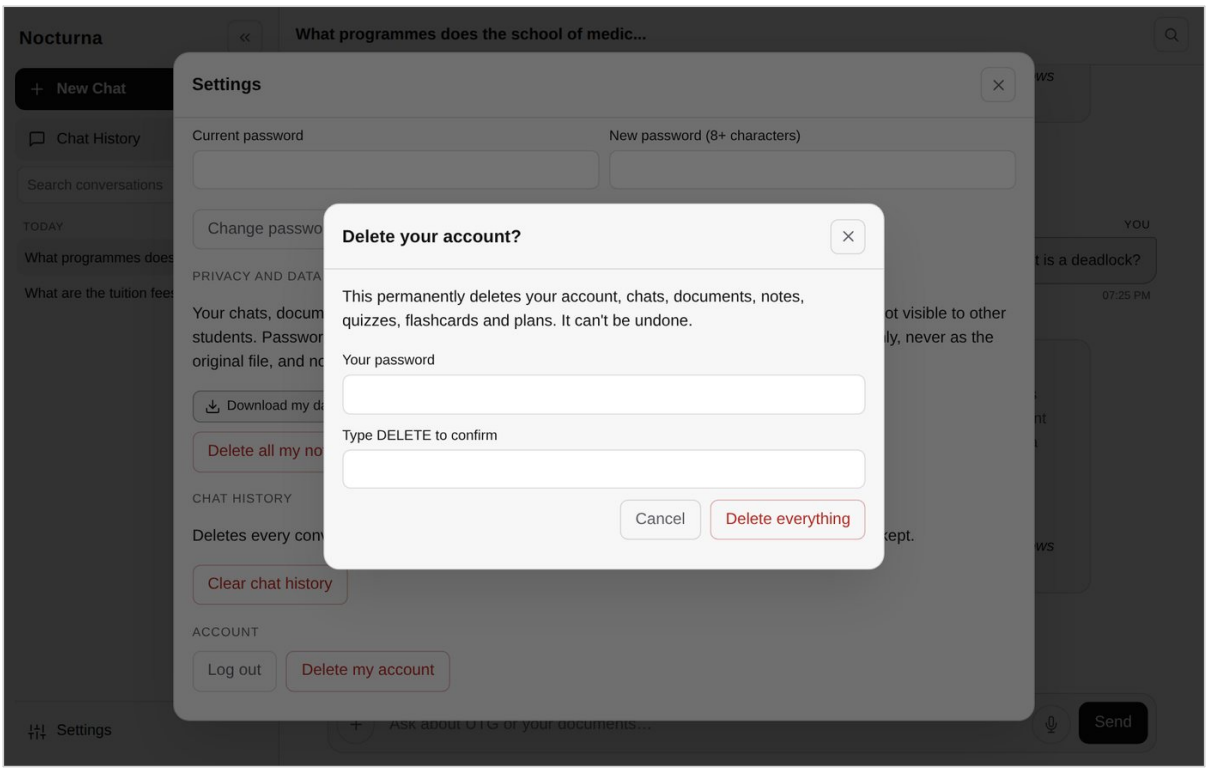


Figure 44: The delete account window. It needs your password and the word DELETE.

> **Warning** Deleting your account cannot be undone. Use **Download my data** first if you want a copy.

17. Using Nocturna on a phone

Nocturna adapts to small screens. The sidebar is hidden to give the conversation more room. Press the menu button at the top left to open it (Figure 46), and tap outside it to close it. All features work the same way as on a computer.

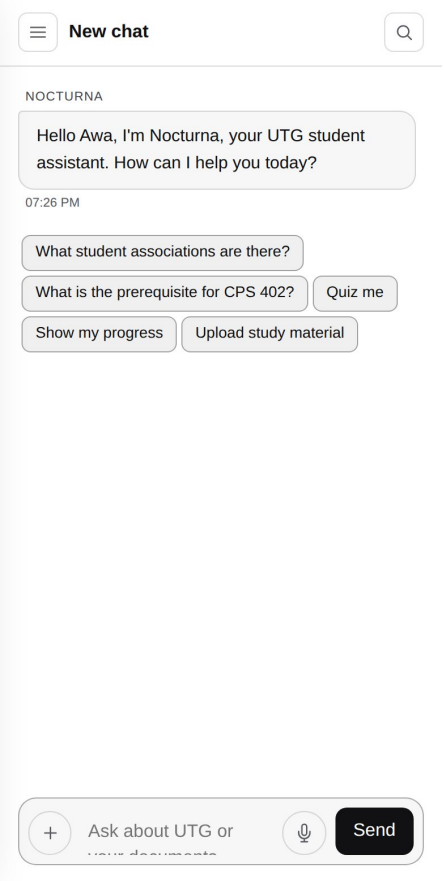


Figure 45: The chat on a phone.

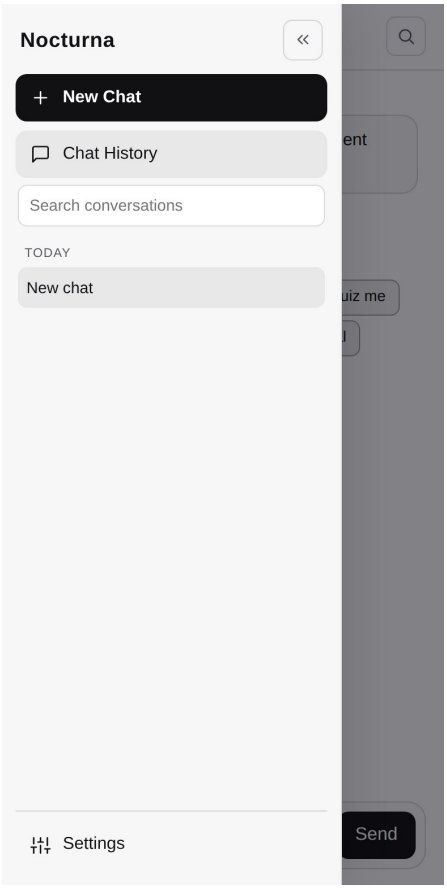


Figure 46: The sidebar opened with the menu button.

18. Your privacy

- Your chats, documents, notes, quizzes, flashcards and progress belong to your account. Other students cannot see them.
- Passwords are never stored. Only a salted, one-way hash is kept.
- Nothing is sent to any AI service. Everything runs on the computer where Nocturna is installed.
- You can download or delete your data at any time (section 16.3).

19. Troubleshooting

Problem	What to try
Sign-up or login says 'Use your UTG student email'	Type your email as first letter of first name + first letter of second name + student number + @utg.edu.gm, for example aj2211234@utg.edu.gm. Personal emails are not accepted.
Sign-up says the letters must match my name	The first two letters of your email must be the first letters of your first and second name as you typed them in the Full name box.
I can't log in with my old account	Accounts made before the UTG email rule used other addresses and can no longer log in. Create a new account with your UTG email.
The page does not open	Check that the terminal running `python app.py` is still open, and that you used http://127.0.0.1:5000.
'ModuleNotFoundError' when starting	Activate the virtual environment and run `pip install -r requirements.txt` again.
Nocturna says 'I'm still learning'	Rephrase using UTG's own words, or type **help**. Nocturna answers only from its UTG data.
An uploaded document shows 'Failed'	The file may be a scan, a photo or damaged. Upload a text-based PDF, Word, PowerPoint, text or Markdown file.
Document answers seem unrelated	In Settings, Documents / RAG, set **Search strictness** to Strict.
Document answers are too short	Raise **Passages per answer**, or set strictness to Relaxed.
The reply takes 5 seconds	This is the designed 'Thinking' pause, not a fault.
Timestamps are missing	Turn on **Show timestamps** in Settings, General.
The theme looks wrong	Choose Light, Dark or System in Settings, General.
The microphone button is missing	Your browser does not support speech input. Try Chrome or Edge.
I forgot my password	There is no email reset because the system is self-contained. Ask the administrator, or create a new account.

20. Quick reference

Action	How
New conversation	Sidebar, New Chat
Send a message	Enter
New line in a message	Shift+Enter
Search and commands	Ctrl+K
Close any window	Esc
Change theme	Settings, General
Show or hide timestamps	Settings, General
Change retrieval options	Settings, Documents / RAG
Clear all chats	Settings, User Profile / Account
Delete my account	Settings, User Profile / Account
Log in	UTG email, for example aj2211234@utg.edu.gm

For markers and developers: run the automated tests with `python -m unittest discover -s tests -v` from the project folder. The suite has 87 tests.